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Early Childhood

The Great Afternoon

Cartoons Are for Life: The Secret Password & The Afternoon Sanctuary

Date: 1994-05-18 at 15:30 America/New_York

3:30 PM — The Secret Password

Three polite, measured knocks sounded against the painted wood of my closed bedroom door just as the red digital clock on the cable converter box ticked to `3:29`.

“Cartoons are for life,” came Katie’s voice through the wood, hushed and completely serious.

The secret password was given. Immediately, I scrambled up off the dark low-pile carpet of my deep-blue bedroom and swung the door open to admit my twin sister just in time for our favorite afternoon block of cartoons. Having just turned nine years old back on April eighth, neither of us cared what the other kids on our street in Virginia Beach were doing after the school bus dropped us off. School was six straight hours of scraping desks, unpredictable bells, and teachers who tried to seat fraternal twins on opposite sides of the hallway just because I was a boy and Katie was a girl. To the teachers at school and the adults in our extended family, I was Nathaniel, though Dad and Katie half the time just called me Nate; behind this door, I was simply the other half of Katie’s perimeter.

Katie slipped inside, her long, straight platinum-blonde hair swinging past her shoulders as she pulled the door shut behind her until the latch clicked. We didn’t need to explain to anyone else why we had a password for a room ten feet away from her own bedroom down the hall. Out in the rest of the house, the afternoon air was already heavy—Mom had locked her bedroom door at two o’clock with another headache and a glass from the kitchen cabinet, and Dad wouldn’t be home from work until five-thirty to start dinner. Behind my closed door, however, the rules belonged entirely to the two of us.

I rushed back across the carpet and pressed the power button on the front of the television and the cable converter box just as the Majestic Studios castle logo and the afternoon cartoon block bumper flashed across the curved glass tube.

The opening brass fanfare of the *Galactic Samurai Geckos* theme song burst out of the small speaker grille, and instantly, both of us got completely carried away. Katie grabbed both of my hands, and for the next sixty seconds we bounced on the balls of our feet in the middle of the carpet, belting out every single word of the intro theme in unison while the animated title cards rolled across the screen.

Then, just as quickly, the final drumbeat of the opening theme faded out, the episode title card appeared, and the two of us were brought gently back to earth.

Without letting go of my hand, Katie dropped down onto the carpet right beside me, leaning her shoulder firmly against mine. I adjusted the volume knob down two notches so the dialogue wouldn't echo into the hallway, rested my back against the side of my bed frame, and let my sister's weight anchor me in place while the afternoon cartoons glowed across the quiet room.

Summer Camp at Virginia Dominion University

The Parallel Pair: Dominion Mall & The VDU Fieldhouse

Date: 1994-07-12 at 08:45 America/New_York

8:45 AM — Two Pairs on Dominion Mall

"All right, Youth Division, let's buddy up in two lines for the walk across Dominion Mall!" Counselor Brad announced over the splash of the circular concrete plaza fountain, tapping his wooden clipboard with a grin.

Standing on the wide, sun-bleached concrete plaza of Virginia Dominion University in Norfolk at eight-forty-five in the morning, wearing matching royal-blue VDU Summer Camp t-shirts over our shorts, Katie immediately tightened her fingers around my right wrist. When our dad, David Prairie, had signed the two of us up for this two-week, all-day camp block—running from nine o'clock in the morning until four o'clock in the afternoon—he had wanted to keep us safely out of the house in July while he was at work. Katie and I had our own rule for surviving six hours a day around fifteen noisy, unfamiliar kids: we were not letting go of each other.

Two paces ahead of us in the Youth Division line, I noticed we weren't the only brother and sister operating on that exact protocol.

A nine-year-old boy with reddish-blond hair and wire-rimmed glasses—whose name tag read *Michael*—and his seven-year-old sister *Rachel*, who had dark shoulder-length hair and glasses of her own, were standing hip-to-hip with their fingers laced together in a white-knuckled grip while their fourteen-year-old sister adjusted her backpack beside them before heading over to the Senior Division group. Just like Katie and me, Michael and Rachel didn't care about the cartoons or baseball cards the other campers were shouting about; they were holding onto each other like their lives depended on it.

Naturally, the two college-age counselors running our Youth Division—Counselor Brad and Counselor Kelly—looked at the four of us and reached the exact wrong conclusion.

"Look at this—we've got two brothers and two sisters right next to each other!" Brad called out brightly. "Let's mix it up today so the boys can hang out with the boys and the girls can hang out with the girls! Michael, step right back here and pair up with Nathaniel! And Rachel, you team up with Katie!"

Before I could protest, Brad guided me a step forward beside Michael, while Kelly gently steered Katie two steps back beside Rachel.

For four seconds, the counselors' geometry held.

I looked sideways at Michael through the thick Tidewater humidity. Michael looked sideways at me behind his wire-rimmed glasses. Neither of us had anything against the other—in fact, I could tell in half a heartbeat that his brain hated the sudden change in the line just as much as mine did. Behind us, Katie wasn't saying a word to Rachel, and Rachel wasn't saying a word to Katie; both of our sisters were staring straight at the backs of our blue camp shirts with their shoulders stiff and their jaws locked tight.

Michael and I didn't need to say a single word out loud. As soon as Counselor Brad turned his back and held his clipboard up in the air to lead the group across the light-gray concrete squares of Dominion Mall, Michael gave me a tiny, solemn nod, and I nodded right back.

I stepped half a pace to my left. Michael stepped half a pace to his right. In the exact same motion, Katie slipped forward to grab my hand again, and Rachel stepped right back into place on Michael's left flank.

By the time our sneakers clicked across the second concrete expansion joint past the circular fountain toward the precast-concrete and blue-glass facade of the University Library, the boy-and-girl experiment was completely over. It was brother and sister on the left, and twin brother and twin sister on the right.

9:30 AM — Terminal 4 and Terminal 5

At nine-thirty, the counselors ushered us out of the ninety-degree heat into the sixty-eight-degree air conditioning of the university computer lab.

Thirty beige desktop towers running *Quantum OS* and curved CRT monitors lined the walls, their cooling fans humming in a low, steady chord behind rows of mechanical *KeyMech* keyboards. I loved computers almost as much as I loved our afternoon cartoons, and Katie loved sitting beside me while we took turns with the mouse and keyboard.

Counselor Brad, however, still hadn't given up on his clipboard chart.

"Okay, campers, listen up!" Brad called out from the front desk, holding up a plastic tray of 3.5-inch floppy disks. "Boys on the left wall row—we've got *Wagon Train West* and *Where on the Map Is Scarlet Devereaux?* loaded up! Girls on the right wall row for *Digit Chompers* and *PixelPaint Junior*!"

Brad pointed Michael to Terminal 4 and guided me into the rolling plastic chair right next to him at Terminal 5. Across the blue carpet, Counselor Kelly led Rachel and Katie to Terminals 19 and 20 against the opposite wall.

The moment Katie's hand left my wrist, the hum of the computer lab stopped feeling calming and started feeling like a trap. Down the row to our left, a boy in a basketball cap was pounding his mechanical spacebar with both thumbs and yelling at the screen as his wagon sank in a river. I didn't touch my keyboard at Terminal 5. Instead, I twisted halfway around in my plastic chair and looked straight across the center aisle.

At Terminal 20, Katie was sitting completely motionless in front of the flashing five-by-five number grid of *Digit Chompers*, twisting the hem of her royal-blue camp shirt around her fingers while looking back across the carpet at me. Right beside her at Terminal 19, Rachel Ragsdale had pulled both hands off her desk and tucked her knuckles tightly against her chest.

Next to me at Terminal 4, Michael pushed his chair back six inches and looked at his sister. At the exact same moment, I tapped the open corner of my desk at Terminal 5 and motioned to Katie.

While Brad was kneeling beside the dot-matrix printer at the front of the room, Katie and Rachel slid off their chairs in perfect synchronization and walked three quiet steps side by side across the carpet.

Rachel squeezed onto the right half of Michael's seat at Terminal 4, and Katie pulled the empty rolling chair from the end of the row right up against my right side at Terminal 5, her long platinum-blonde hair brushing my sleeve as she exhaled a long, quiet breath of relief.

"Hey, girls, your computers are still running over on the right wall—" Counselor Kelly started, walking down the aisle before stopping short as she took in the two identical brother-and-sister teams sitting shoulder-to-shoulder at Terminals 4 and 5.

"She's playing with me," Michael told her quietly from Terminal 4, his left hand resting on the arrow keys while Rachel's right thumb hovered over the spacebar for *Digit Chompers*. "I steer the square, and Rachel chomps the multiples. That's how we play."

I rested my left hand on the keyboard of Terminal 5 and placed Katie's hand over the beige two-button mouse for *Wagon Train West*.

"Katie's my twin," I said, looking up at Kelly with quiet, unshakable certainty. "We always play together."

Kelly looked from Michael and Rachel to Katie and me. Neither pair was making noise, neither pair was arguing, and the panicked stiffness had vanished from all four of us the second the sisters were back beside their brothers. Slowly, Kelly smiled, pulled an extra chair over for Rachel so both pairs had two seats pushed flush together, and jotted a quick note on her clipboard.

"Okay," Kelly said gently. "Michael and Rachel on Terminal 4, Nathaniel and Katie on Terminal 5."

For the next hour and a half, Katie and I guided our pixel wagon all the way across the western rivers without losing a single ox—trading turns with the mouse while Michael and Rachel cleared screen after screen of *Digit Chompers* two feet to our left.

1:30 PM — Pair 1 and Pair 2 at the Fieldhouse Pool

After eating our grilled cheese sandwiches side by side in the Monarch Commons dining hall at noon—just a few seats down from where Michael and Rachel's fourteen-year-old sister Jessica used her written lunch exception on the camp roster to sit with them and quiz them on campus landmarks—our group walked down Hampton Boulevard to the VDU Fieldhouse.

The Fieldhouse was a massive brick athletic building where the Lady Admirals played women's basketball during the school year while the men's team played downtown under the concrete dome of the Norfolk Prism. Down the rubber-floored hallway, through the double doors of the Fieldhouse Natatorium, the indoor swimming pool echoed with splashing water and bouncing whistles.

As soon as I stepped out of the boys' locker room in my swim trunks, Katie stepped out of the girls' locker room door in her navy one-piece swimsuit, walked straight across the wet white tile, and grabbed my hand with both of hers. Right next to us on the bench, Rachel Ragsdale did the exact same thing with Michael.

Up on the deck beside the white plastic Buddy Board, Counselor Brad held up his thick black grease pencil and tried the gender split one last time.

"Every fifteen minutes when the lifeguard blows the long whistle and yells *Buddy Check*, you and your buddy have to find each other in the shallow end, grab hands, and hold them up in the air!" Brad called out over the echoing cavern. "Michael and Nathaniel, you guys are Pair Four! Rachel and Katie, you two are Pair Nine!"

Katie squeezed my fingers tightly as thirty kids splashed into the pool at once. I didn't let go of her hand, and four feet to my left, Michael didn't let go of Rachel's. Together, both pairs walked down the wide fiberglass steps into the warm, three-foot shallow end along the side wall.

Two minutes later, the head lifeguard on the high white chair raised his silver whistle to his lips.

TWEEEEET!

"BUDDY CHECK!" the lifeguard shouted through his red megaphone. "Find your buddy and hands in the air!"

Out in the middle of the shallow end, kids who had been chasing each other in *Admirals and Anchors* pool tag splashed around in circles trying to remember who their assigned partner was.

Along the shallow wall, Katie's left hand was already laced tightly through my right hand, and Rachel's right hand was already laced tightly through Michael's left. Before the whistle had even stopped echoing off the steel roof trusses of the Fieldhouse, all four of us raised our joined hands straight into the air above the water.

Up on the deck, Counselor Brad stared at our two pairs of raised brother-and-sister hands, looked at Counselor Kelly laughing softly behind her clipboard, and finally surrendered. Wiping his rag across the grease pencil on the white plastic board, Brad wrote two new permanent assignments at the very top of the list:

PAIR 1: MICHAEL + RACHEL PAIR 2: NATHANIEL + KATIE

Katie looked at me as we lowered our arms back into the warm water, a bright, triumphant smile breaking across her face, and across the lane Michael and Rachel shared the exact same quiet grin. For the rest of the two-week camp block—from the morning walk across Dominion Mall to afternoon *Four-in-a-Row Grid* and *Wild Draw* cards in the Fieldhouse multipurpose room—nobody at Virginia Dominion University ever tried to separate either pair of siblings again.

Big Family Christmas

The Newport News ARTS Train & The Downstairs Sofa Bed

Date: 1994-12-23 at 18:15 America/New_York

6:15 PM — The Newport News ARTS Platform

The evening train pulled into the brick ARTS—American Rail Transit Service—station in Newport News with a long hiss of air brakes and a cloud of white steam rising into the cold December air.

Up on the concrete platform, Katie and I stood side by side in our winter coats with our hands tucked into our pockets, watching the stainless-steel ARTS passenger doors slide open. Moments later, Grandma, our Aunt Elizabeth, and our nine-year-old cousin Chelsea stepped down onto the platform carrying their holiday suitcases, and the whole family crowded together to exchange hugs and greetings.

True to form, before we had even walked ten feet past the station canopy toward the parking lot, Aunt Elizabeth wasted no time digging into her coat pocket and lighting up a cigarette.

Beside us, Chelsea immediately scowled and angrily plugged her nose with two fingers.

“Mom, that’s gross,” Chelsea stammered, waving a hand in front of her face as all of us were forced to stand on the cold curb waiting before we could load into the vehicles.

“Liz, put that out,” our dad snapped, his breath fogging in the December chill as he hefted two suitcases into the trunk of our Holt sedan. “You know damn well that’s not good for you!”

“Alright, alright,” Aunt Liz snapped back, stubbing the cigarette out on the heel of her boot as we sorted ourselves into the two vehicles for the drive back across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel.

Chelsea climbed into the middle of the back bench seat of the Holt sedan right between Katie and me, while Dad and Aunt Liz sat up front. Behind us, Mom—who was having a rare sober evening so Grandma wouldn’t ask questions at the ARTS station—drove Grandma in the pickup truck following our taillights down Interstate 64.

As soon as our sedan cleared the tunnel and turned onto the familiar streets of Virginia Beach, Katie leaned forward slightly to look across Chelsea at me, her eyes bright with holiday excitement.

“Welcome to Virginia Beach!” Katie squealed happily, squeezing Chelsea’s mittened hand. “Now, the three of us are going to have to squeeze into one room!”

8:00 PM — Downstairs Sanctuary

When we pulled into the driveway at home, Katie, Chelsea, and I pitched in right away to help Grandma and Aunt Liz carry their overnight bags through the front door.

Standing at the foot of the stairs in the foyer, Dad laid out the holiday room assignments.

“You three will share the sofa bed,” Dad said to us kids, gesturing toward the living room. Turning to the adults, he added, “Mom, Katie’s room is closer to the upstairs bathroom. Liz, you get Nathaniel’s room.”

In a lot of houses, getting evicted from both of our upstairs bedrooms for the holidays would have felt like a punishment. To Katie and me, however, Dad had just handed us the greatest logistical gift of Christmas. With Grandma in Katie’s room, Aunt Liz in my room, and Mom and Dad behind their closed door at the end of the upstairs hall, all four adults were confined to the second floor—which meant the entire first floor belonged exclusively to the three of us kids.

“Chelsea, there’s a bathroom down here we can use,” Katie explained immediately, pointing down the short hallway off the living room. “It has a shower. We can stay downstairs while the adults are upstairs.”

“Okay,” our cousin replied, setting her backpack by the couch. “Where do we sleep?”

“The three of us will sleep down here. This sofa is a sofa bed,” Katie replied proudly as the three of us finished carrying the last of the adults’ bags up the stairs.

Because the train had arrived late in the evening, dinner was fast and simple—warm bowls of soup and buttered rolls around the dining table—and before nine o’clock, the adults retreated upstairs for the night, leaving the first floor completely to the three of us.

“I want to take a shower,” Chelsea announced to Katie and me once the upstairs footsteps quieted down.

Katie walked her down the short hall to show her how to turn the downstairs shower faucet on and where the clean towels were stacked, then came back out into the living room where I had already changed into my long-sleeved flannel pajamas and was busy pulling the heavy metal frame of the sofa bed out from inside the couch. Working together, Katie and I unfolded the mattress, smoothed out the clean cotton sheets, and spread two thick winter quilts across the top.

A few minutes later, the bathroom door clicked open. Instead of putting her pajamas on inside the bathroom, Chelsea wandered straight out into the living room wrapped only in a bath towel, making her way casually toward the sofa bed Katie and I had just finished setting up.

“CHELSEA!” Katie stammered, her hand shooting out in a flash to clamp firmly over my eyes. “Your cousin shouldn’t be seeing all of you!”

Before Chelsea could even blink, Katie spun her right back around by the shoulders and shunted her straight back into the downstairs bathroom to finish drying off and put her flannel pajamas on properly.

“You need to stop blushing,” my twin sister admonished me once the bathroom door clicked shut behind Chelsea—except she didn’t truly admonish me at all, letting out a quiet, bubbly giggle as she took her hand off my face. “You promise not to tell anyone?”

“Promise,” I replied, rubbing the bridge of my nose as we both climbed onto the left side of the wide sofa bed in our flannel pajamas and pulled the heavy winter quilt up to our chins.

“You know Chelsea sometimes forgets the rules when she’s in a different house,” Katie whispered, leaning her head against my shoulder underneath the quilt and lacing her fingers through mine. “As long as we look out for each other down here, nobody upstairs is going to yell at anyone.”

“Not a word to anyone,” I whispered back, squeezing her hand.

Two minutes later, Chelsea came back out of the hallway wearing her full green flannel pajamas, fuzzy socks, and a sheepish grin, and climbed under the quilt on the far side of the sofa bed. With the living room lamp clicked off and only the colored lights of the Christmas tree glowing softly in the corner, Katie stayed tucked right against my side—the two of us holding down our downstairs sanctuary while the winter wind rattled the front windows.

Middle School & The Blizzard of ’96

The Blizzard of ’96

Snow Day in Virginia Beach & The Backyard Promise

Date: 1996-01-06 at 11:30 America/New_York

11:30 AM — Waiting for the First Flakes

“You think we’re going to have snow?” Katie asked, her breath fogging a small circle on the cold glass pane as the two of us stood shoulder to shoulder at my upstairs bedroom window.

“Hope so. SNOW DAY!” I said, practically vibrating with excitement as I pressed my palms against the wooden sill and looked out at our residential street in Virginia Beach.

Outside on the first Saturday of January 1996, it was bitterly cold, and heavy, slate-gray clouds were rolling in off the Atlantic until the sky looked like brushed steel. Behind us on my bedroom stand, the local Norfolk GBS news station had cut into regular Saturday morning programming, the meteorologist standing in front of a swirling radar map warning all of Hampton Roads to prepare for the Blizzard of ’96. Even on a Saturday, a real blizzard meant Monday and Tuesday would be wiped clean off the school calendar.

“Snow,” Katie replied hopefully, leaning her shoulder against mine as the news anchor continued to drone on and on about wind gusts, coastal flooding, and how many inches were expected later in the afternoon. Both of us were thrilled at the thought of the whole neighborhood shutting down.

At twelve-thirty, while Katie and I were sitting side by side at the kitchen table eating our lunch sandwiches, the first white flakes began to drift past the dining room window. At first it wasn’t much—just fine, powdery crystals swirling across the dry grass—but within twenty minutes the flakes grew thick and steady, dusting the wooden fence rails and the roof of Dad’s car.

“Wonder if it will stick,” Katie giggled, pointing her finger toward the patio.

By late afternoon, it didn’t just stick; it buried the entire backyard under a clean, silent blanket of white.

Inside the house, however, the quiet didn’t last. Around five o’clock, the familiar, sharp sound of Mom’s and Dad’s voices started rising from the upstairs hallway—first a slammed cabinet door, then the bitter, overlapping shouting match that always followed whenever Dad found another empty bottle hidden behind the pantry cans.

5:45 PM — The Backyard Bear Hug

Katie and I didn’t wait for the yelling to reach the staircase. We pulled on our heavy winter jackets and boots and slipped out the back door into the twilight snow.

Out in the backyard, inside the perimeter of our white wooden picket fence, the falling snow acted like a giant acoustic blanket over the neighborhood. The streetlamps glowed pale orange through the swirling flakes, and every footstep made a soft, muted crunch under our shoes.

Standing near the center of the yard with the snow settling onto my short blonde hair, the cold wind hit my face, and all at once the weight of everything we had been carrying over the past year caught up with me. My chest tightened, and before I could stop myself, I started sniffling in the cold air.

Katie turned around immediately. She didn’t hesitate for a second—she stepped straight through the snow and pulled me into a tight, fierce bear hug, wrapping both of her blue-jacketed arms around my shoulders.

“What’s wrong?” Katie asked softly against my ear, holding onto me with all her strength.

“I’m just so happy you’re willing to do all of this for me,” I whispered into her shoulder, my voice shaking slightly as I held onto the back of her winter coat, unsure of how to put the rest of the knot in my chest into words.

Katie didn’t need me to explain it. Because she was my twin, she already knew the exact two things crushing my ribs.

“You’re still upset with last year, and that girl everyone thought you had a crush on?” Katie asked gently.

“Yes, I am,” I whimpered, burying my face against her collar, overwhelmingly grateful that my twin sister was hugging me instead of telling me to toughen up. All through the previous spring at school, a pack of kids in our grade had latched onto a rumor that I had a crush on a girl in our homeroom, turning every hallway change and cafeteria period into a relentless, mocking gauntlet that wouldn’t stop no matter what I said. “And it does not help that Mom and Dad are arguing with each other again. I just want to enjoy the snow without the screaming.”

“I’m right here, and I will never leave you,” Katie replied fiercely, pulling me into an even tighter bear hug as the heavy January snow came down all around us in the twilight. “I’m your sister, and I would just never, ever leave you.”

She held onto me for a long moment in the quiet yard, letting the steady pressure of her arms slow my breathing down, before she spoke again.

“Your classmates are mean,” Katie continued, her voice firm against the cold wind. “Especially when they refuse to back down. When we go back to school, I will gladly play my part of pretend girlfriend so they leave you alone.”

“Thank you, but I think everyone knows that you’re my sister,” I whispered, managing a small, shaky laugh even as my teeth started chattering from the twenty-degree air.

“Come on, let’s head back inside before we freeze,” Katie said, taking my hand and leading me back across the snow-covered grass toward the back door.

Inside the warm kitchen, the shouting upstairs had finally stopped—Mom had gone to bed for the night, and the house was still again. Standing beside the dark green laminate counter with the snow piling up against the dining room window glass behind us, Katie wrapped her arms around my neck for one more long, warming hug until the chill left my fingers.

“Let’s use my bed tonight,” I whispered as we started walking up the stairs together. “This way we can see the street from my window when we wake up in the morning.”

“Sure,” Katie smiled. “I hope we wake up to snow on the ground like there is right now.”

At the top of the landing, I paused outside my bedroom door and looked at her. “Real quick, if you’re going to spend the night with me: what should we do about getting changed?”

“I’ll go change into my warm pajamas in my room and grab my pillow, and I’ll knock when I’m ready,” Katie whispered with a practical nod.

Three minutes later, after I had pulled on my own heavy winter flannel pajamas and climbed under the covers by the window, three quiet knocks sounded against my door.

“Cartoons are for life,” Katie whispered from the hall.

“Come on in,” I whispered back.

Carrying her pillow under her arm in her purple fleece pajamas, Katie crossed the carpet and climbed under the heavy blanket right at my side. Outside my bedroom window, the Blizzard of ’96 howled silently across Virginia Beach, piling deep drifts against the curb under the glow of the streetlamp, while inside the warm perimeter of my bed, my twin sister and I fell fast asleep holding hands.

Katie Is Dumped

No More Fighting & The Dinner Dance Promise

Date: 1997-10-16 at 16:15 America/New_York

4:15 PM — Tears Under the Blue Butterfly

“Leave me alone! You’d never understand,” Katie sobbed, turning her head half away as I pushed her bedroom door open and stepped onto the carpet.

I had just walked up the stairs after seventh grade when I heard the sound echoing right through her hollow wooden door into the upstairs hallway. Katie was standing near the foot of her bed against the bright magenta-purple wall beneath her framed blue morpho butterfly print, crying up a storm with her shoulders shaking inside her dark navy t-shirt and both hands pressed over her face.

For the first month of middle school—while I spent my afternoons quiet in my blue bedroom with my *Nova 64* video games and Katie tried her hardest to fit in with the girls from her English class and a seventh-grade boy named Donnie—the stress of the loud hallways and Mom’s worsening drinking at home had pushed the two of us into the stupid habit of bickering whenever we passed each other in the hall.

Hearing the ragged sound of her crying, I dropped every trace of that irritation at the door. Stepping quietly across her room, I placed my hand gently on her shoulder.

“What is it?” I asked softly.

Katie continued sobbing for several seconds, her chest heaving as she tried to catch her breath. I realized immediately that this wasn’t a small hallway argument—this was serious. It took her a long moment to realize that I wasn’t going to tease her or make fun of her for crying.

Slowly, she lowered her hands from her tear-streaked face.

“Donnie dumped me,” Katie choked out, fresh tears spilling down her cheeks. “I loved him, and he dumped me!”

I reached my hand out to gently wipe the tears from her eyes. Never having had a girlfriend myself—and never having been dumped—I didn’t fully understand the mechanics of middle-school romance, but I didn’t need to understand romance to see how badly my twin sister was hurting.

Katie reached out with both hands and took mine, holding onto my fingers tightly as if she were drowning and I was the only solid ground in the room.

“Please… don’t let go,” she whispered, her voice raw.

I closed both of my hands around hers and held on firmly. Looking straight into my eyes with a sudden, desperate seriousness, Katie asked the question that mattered most to survival in a middle-school cafeteria:

“Will you sit with me at lunch?”

The look on Katie’s upset face told me the only answer she needed to hear—and it was the exact answer I wanted to give her anyway.

“Yes,” I answered without hesitation. “I’ll sit with you at lunch.”

Katie burst into fresh tears of pure relief, letting go of my fingers only to throw both arms around my neck and pull me into a tight hug.

“Thank you,” she whispered against my shoulder.

I could hear how raspy and sore her throat was from all of her crying, so I offered to run downstairs and get her a cold glass of water, but she shook her head and held onto my shirt even tighter. As I wrapped my arms around her waist and hugged her back in the quiet room, I felt something shift permanently inside my chest. All the petty squabbling we had done over the past few weeks felt completely, utterly stupid. Katie didn’t want to stop hugging me, and I didn’t have a single problem with that.

“Please, no more fighting,” my sister sobbed softly into my shoulder.

“I understand,” I promised, resting my chin against the top of her blonde hair as we continued to hold onto each other.

“I’m still upset, but thanks for this,” Katie murmured a minute later as I felt a few more warm tears soak into the shoulder of my maroon t-shirt.

“Katie, I’m here for you,” I told her. And as I said the words out loud, squeezing my arms around my twin sister, I realized just how much more I loved hugging her and keeping her safe than arguing with her.

5:00 PM — The Pretend Date & PB&J Sanctuary

When her crying finally began to subside, the two of us sat down side by side on the edge of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread, our shoulders pressed together and our hands still linked.

“Thank you,” Katie said quietly, wiping her eyes with the back of her wrist. “Thank you for being there for me. Someday, I know I’m going to repay this.”

She went quiet for a beat, looking down at our joined hands, before she suddenly whispered:

“Take me to the Dinner Dance this week.”

The seventh-grade Dinner Dance was tomorrow night in the school cafeteria, and half the reason Katie had been crying so hard was the thought of either staying home alone in embarrassment or walking into that room by herself while Donnie was there.

“Of course we can go together,” I said immediately, knowing I didn’t have a date of my own—and wouldn’t have wanted to go with anyone else even if I did. “Even though you’re my sister, we will go on a pretend date.”

“Oh, thank you. Thank you,” Katie breathed, the last of the heavy sobs finally leaving her chest as she leaned her head against my shoulder.

“Would you like it if I made you dinner tonight?” I asked, deciding right then and there to start playing my part as her protective pretend boyfriend.

“Let’s just have something simple, like sandwiches,” she said softly.

“Alright,” I replied, giving her hand a gentle squeeze as the two of us stood up and headed downstairs together.

In the quiet kitchen, I made us both thick peanut-butter-and-jelly sandwiches and poured two tall glasses of cold milk to soothe her sore throat. After we finished eating at the table, Katie looked across at me.

“Could we watch a movie together?” she asked.

“Sure,” I replied warmly. “Let’s pick something together.”

We walked back upstairs to my deep-blue bedroom, picked out our VHS tape of *House Guard 2: Lost in Manhattan* from the shelf beneath my television stand, and pushed it into the VCR. As the opening Majestic Studios credits began to roll across the CRT screen, Katie kicked off her shoes and climbed into my single bed right at my side, resting her head on my shoulder and pulling the blanket across our legs.

Near the end of the movie, when the closing music faded in, I glanced down and saw that my sister was fast asleep against my arm, her breathing slow and completely peaceful after an afternoon of crying her eyes out.

I reached carefully for the remote, clicked the television off, and decided right then to let her sleep. I decided that I would tell her that I didn’t mind after we woke up in the morning. Katie was exhausted, and the last thing I wanted was to see her become a grouch because she was woken back up without enough sleep. Part of me

marveled at how natural it felt sharing my narrow bed with my twin sister again—just like we had during the Blizzard of ’96 and on the downstairs sofa bed at Christmas. We had chosen this close brother-and-sister bond together, and enjoying the warm, quiet company of the person who mattered most to me in the world, I slid down onto the pillow beside her and let myself drift off to sleep at her side.

The Pretend Boyfriend & Twins’ Day

Twin Brothers Always Stay: Spirit Week & The Living Room Sofa

Date: 1997-10-17 at 07:30 America/New_York

7:30 AM — “Twin Brothers Always Stay”

The next morning, when the pale autumn sunlight filtered through the blinds of my bedroom, I woke up first—and sure enough, Katie was still fast asleep right at my side in the small bed.

“Katie,” I whispered softly, gently prodding her shoulder so I wouldn’t startle her in case she didn’t realize right away that she had fallen asleep in my room the night before.

My sister stirred against the pillow, blinking her blue eyes open in the quiet blue room before looking from the wall to me in mild surprise.

“Morning, sleepyhead,” I whispered with a small smile.

“I slept in your bed?” she asked groggily, rubbing her eyes.

“Yep, and I did not mind,” I replied, looking her straight in the eye. “Let’s play a game together.”

For the first time since Donnie had broken her heart yesterday afternoon, Katie’s face lit up with genuine excitement. While she sat up against the headboard, I slipped out of bed, walked across the carpet to the television stand, and powered on my *Nova 64* video game console. I was still in full protective-brother mode, determined to keep cheering her up until I heard her laugh again.

Before I picked up the controller, I turned back to face her.

“I’m your brother. I will always be here for you. Promise,” I told her, my voice steady and earnest in the quiet room. I paused for half a beat, then added the truth I knew we would live by for the rest of our lives: “Boyfriends come and go, but Twin Brothers always stay. Always.”

Before the console title screen had even finished loading on the CRT television, I found myself wrapped in Katie’s arms again. She stood up from the edge of the mattress and hugged me with everything she had, making it unmistakably clear that she had no intention of letting go of me. She held onto my shoulders while the video game rolled through its opening demo sequence on the screen behind us, then sat down on the carpet right at my side.

“We should probably get dressed,” Katie said after a moment, glancing down at her wrinkled shirt from yesterday. “Guess I will pop into my room real quick. Leave the game on this screen while we get dressed?”

“Sure,” I replied, gently ushering her to the bedroom door. “I’ll open my door when I’m dressed.”

8:00 AM — Spirit Week: Twins’ Day

Five minutes later, after I had pulled on a clean maroon short-sleeve t-shirt, medium-wash blue jeans, and my tan sneakers, I opened my bedroom door. Katie walked right back in from across the hall—and the second I saw what she had picked out of her closet, I had to grin.

Without planning it, she had put on the exact same shade of maroon short-sleeve t-shirt and medium-wash blue jeans with a dark belt.

“Next week is Spirit Week at school,” I said as she stepped into the room. “Want to have a little fun on Twins’ Day, since, well, we *are* twins?”

Katie giggled as I handed her the second black controller from the floor stand. “Yeah, we are twins! Wonder how many others will really be twins compared to how many will do it just for fun.”

We both laughed out loud at that remark, and right there in front of my computer desk and television stand, we stubbornly made up our minds.

“I think it’s settled, then,” I declared. “We will dress exactly the same, and we will enter the contest.”

We laughed again, already looking forward to seeing how the teachers and our classmates would react to actual fraternal twins walking into the Spirit Week Twins’ Day assembly dressed identically and holding hands.

“Too bad we don’t have matching shoes,” Katie remarked, looking down at her grey-and-red sneakers next to my tan ones.

“Ah, well. Still, let’s do what we can. I think these pants and shirts look close enough,” I said, setting the controllers on the desk and pulling her into another tight, standing hug in the middle of the room. Both of us laughed into each other’s shoulders, our matching maroon sleeves wrapped around each other’s backs. Yesterday’s tears were completely gone.

5:30 PM — Macaroni & Cheese on the Living Room Sofa

Later that evening, after spending the afternoon practicing our co-op levels and getting ready for the weekend, Katie and I walked downstairs and decided to sit together on the tan-brown living room sofa, curling up side by side while we waited for dinner to be made.

As usual in our house, Dad was in the kitchen working over the stove after a full day at his job, while upstairs Mom was already passed out drunk in bed behind her closed door.

“Mac and cheese is what I smell,” I whispered as Katie slid flush against my right side on the sofa cushions, draped her left arm warmly around my shoulders, and rested her right hand across my forearm to hold me close to her.

“Our favorite,” she replied softly, resting her cheek near my shoulder as the two of us sat there, happily snuggled up together beneath the blue-framed underwater painting on the living room wall.

We had a few quiet minutes to ourselves before the timer on the stove went off, and neither of us wanted to get off the sofa. After years of feeling like we had to keep our guard up against loud classrooms and the unpredictable storms upstairs, snuggling together on the couch felt like the safest, most comfortable place on earth.

As we sat there in the warm glow of the living room lamp, Katie whispered, “Snuggling up is just so comfortable.”

“It is,” I replied quietly, leaning into the warmth of her arm around my shoulders. Neither of us moved an inch; we were both completely content holding onto each other and letting the rest of the house fade away.

A few minutes later, Dad stepped to the doorway of the dining room with a pot holder in his hand, looking over at the two of us curled up together on the couch before calling us in to eat.

When we sat down side by side at the dining table over our steaming bowls of macaroni and cheese, Dad looked across the table at the two of us, his tired eyes softening with genuine gratitude.

“I really appreciate that you both don’t fight and argue with each other,” Dad said quietly, his voice heavy with emotion. “Honestly, I wish your mother didn’t drink her life away. I want to do my best to not only be your father, but also be a proper dad to both of you. Your mother’s drinking is not your fault, and I don’t want either of you to think that. Please don’t let your grades suffer because of it.”

Underneath the edge of the dining table, Katie reached her hand over and laced her fingers tightly through mine, and I squeezed right back. Whatever happened upstairs, and whatever happened in the hallways at school, my twin sister and I had our sanctuary—and we were never letting go.

Sixteen & Summer Sanctuary

Bonding With My Sister

Summer Sanctuary: Hearthstone Pizza, The Sunlit Valley, & Katie's Room

Date: 2001-06-18 at 08:30 America/New_York

8:30 AM — First Full Day of Summer

"Summer is here," I said, blinking open my eyes as the warm June sunlight filtered through the blinds of Katie's bedroom.

"Our first full day with the house to ourselves," my sister replied softly as we started waking up.

Having both turned sixteen back on April eighth, the two of us were curled up side by side in our pajamas on top of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread beneath the framed blue morpho butterfly artwork hanging on her magenta-purple wall, completely used to being pretend dates and full-time anchors for each other. With both of our parents already gone for their morning shifts and two quiet weeks stretching ahead of us before Summer School started, the entire house was finally calm.

Katie rubbed her eyes, then looked over at me and asked, "Get dressed and have breakfast?"

"Sure, I am getting hungry," I replied, giving her hand a quick squeeze as I climbed out of bed.

I stepped across the upstairs hallway into my own deep-blue painted bedroom to pull on a clean maroon crew-neck t-shirt and jeans while Katie changed in her room, and two minutes later we met right back at her doorway, exchanging a warm, familiar smile before making our way down the stairs together.

"Let's just have some cereal, then we will figure out what we want to do for the day," I said as we reached the bottom landing. "I want to spend the day with just you."

Our stomachs were calling us, as was our daily routine of taking our morning dose of medication before the day got underway. In the quiet kitchen, I pulled two ceramic bowls out from the cupboard and set our morning medication tablets beside two glasses of water while we picked out our cereal from the pantry—being twins, of course it was the exact same box—and sat down at the kitchen table, pulling our chairs right up against each other so we were as close as possible.

After we took our morning medication and started on our cereal, my twin sister reached across the table, took my hand, and looked straight into my eyes.

"What would you like to do today?" Katie asked.

“I was thinking of snuggling on the sofa over a movie,” I suggested as we continued eating our breakfast side by side.

“I know just the movie I want to watch,” my sister said, squeezing my hand. She gave me that unmistakable look like she had a big secret and started giggling. She wanted me to ask what movie it was, but after sixteen years as her twin brother, I knew she wouldn’t tell me—I would have to wait and see what it was when she popped the tape into the VCR.

Since I had made breakfast, Katie took it upon herself to carry our bowls and spoons over to the counter and load our dishes into the dishwasher.

“I will get the tape, then will join you on the sofa,” Katie called over her shoulder as I headed toward the living room.

“Alright, Katie,” I replied, settling onto the cushions of our tan-brown living room sofa beside the coffee table, where Dad had neatly stacked the slightly outdated *Quantum Basic 5.0* programming textbooks—complete with clear plastic mylar covers and barcode stickers on the spines—that he had checked out from the Virginia Beach Public Library to get a head start on his upcoming fall *Quantum Basic 6.0* class at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR. Over the past few weeks, Katie had started reading Dad’s library books cover to cover and teaching the programming exercises to me, and when Dad found out, he had beamed with pride and actively encouraged both of us to keep coding.

Even better, when Summer School started in two weeks, Katie and I weren’t going because we were behind. We had intentionally signed up to knock out an academic credit over the summer so that when our main high-school year started in September, our schedules would line up with a free period and lunch block together every single day. Until those summer classes began, I was looking forward to having unbroken time with my twin sister.

9:30 AM — *Hearthstone Pizza & Journey to the Sunlit Valley*

A minute later, Katie walked into the living room holding a familiar white clamshell VHS tape behind her back, slid the cassette into the VCR beneath the television, and walked over to sit on the sofa right next to me.

Immediately, she lifted her arm and made it clear she wanted me to snuggle up in her arms. I slid flush against her side and rested my head against her shoulder, glad that I got to curl up with Katie now that the two of us had become so close.

Across the room, the CRT television flickered to life. My eyes lit up as the sweeping orchestral welcome theme to one of our favorite companies—*Majestic Studios*—played across the screen, and then my eyes lit up even further as the previews transitioned and I recognized the exact childhood VHS movie that my sister had put on for us: *Journey to the Sunlit Valley*.

“I knew you would like it,” Katie whispered, resting her cheek against my hair as she looked down into my eyes.

“Of course,” I whispered back with a grin as the tape rolled through its iconic opening bumper before the feature presentation—the familiar, upbeat birthday party commercial from *Hearthstone Pizza* where the older brother was supposed to be nice to the little girl.

We happily stayed curled up together on the cushions as Sprout and his friends began their journey across the screen, wanting nothing more than to sit there quietly in each other’s arms watching the movie. Both of our parents were away at work, the house was completely peaceful, and we had decided that all we wanted was each other—just brother-and-sister time together in our sanctuary before Summer School was set to begin.

9:00 PM — Katie’s Room Beneath the Blue Butterfly

By the time evening rolled around and the June twilight faded outside the living room windows, we had spent the entire day side by side without a single argument, a single raised voice, or a single interruption from the outside world.

As we walked up the stairs together after dinner and paused on the second-floor landing between my blue-painted bedroom and her magenta-purple bedroom, Katie turned to me and took my hand.

“Share a bed?” Katie asked softly.

“Sure,” I replied without hesitation. “Your room or mine?”

“How about my room tonight,” Katie suggested with a gentle smile.

After I stepped into my blue room to brush my teeth and change into a comfortable t-shirt and flannel pajama pants, I crossed the hall and knocked lightly on Katie’s door. Inside her room, under the warm amber glow of the bedside lamp and the framed blue morpho butterfly on her wall, we climbed onto her bed together, propped our pillows against the headboard, and pulled the green-and-gold covers across our legs. Katie draped her arm around my shoulders and laced her fingers through mine, and as the house settled into quiet around us, we drifted off to sleep side by side.

End of Summer Cruise

Part 1: Part 1: The I-95 Haul, The Quantum Basic Library Book, & Ditching Captain Barnaby

Date: 2001-08-19 at 09:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 18, 2001 — The Twelve-Hour Grumble Down I-95

"If `Command1_Click` calls the subroutine before the text box validates, the whole form throws a type-mismatch error," Katie murmured beside me in the back seat of our Holt sedan, tapping her finger against page 142 of the thick paperback resting across our knees as another green Florida mileage sign flashed past the window on Interstate 95 South.

"That's only in *Quantum Basic 5.0*," our dad, David Prairie, called back from the driver's seat, his eyes flicking warmly to the rearview mirror despite the fatigue of ten straight hours behind the wheel. "Wait until we test it on the *Quantum Basic 6.0* compiler at the CCHR lab next month. Though I'll be honest with you two—I'd a whole lot rather be sitting at our kitchen table in Virginia Beach testing that code right now than driving to Port Canaveral."

"So would we, Dad," I grumbled, shifting my stiff legs on the bench seat while Katie laced her left hand through my right.

None of the three of us—not Dad, not Katie, and not me—had wanted to go on this seven-day Caribbean cruise at the end of August. Back in July, Katie and I had worked hard through our high-school summer school class, knocking out a required academic credit early so that when eleventh grade started in September, our main school-year schedules would free up for a shared lunch block together every single day. All the three of us had wanted for the final two weeks of summer was to stay home in peace so Dad could study for his upcoming fall semester at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR.

To get a head start before classes began, Dad had gone to the Virginia Beach Public Library and checked out the newest programming manual they had left on the shelf—a slightly outdated, dog-eared copy of *Learn Quantum Basic 5.0 in 21 Days* wrapped in a clear plastic mylar library jacket with a barcode sticker on the spine. Within forty-eight hours of Dad setting that book on the dining table, Katie had started reading it cover to cover and teaching the event loops and form layouts to me on my bedroom computer. When Dad caught us working through his library book together, he hadn't been upset at all; he had beamed with pride and started actively encouraging both of us to follow our dreams.

Up in the front passenger seat, however, our mother, Brenda, hadn't cared about Dad's CCHR classes, our summer school credit, or the fact that twelve hours crammed into a sedan was making Katie's and my legs ache from hip to ankle. Mom had insisted on booking this seven-day Eastern Caribbean cruise—and when we finally rolled over the causeway into Port Canaveral on Saturday afternoon, the visual irony hit Katie and me right through the windshield.

Docked at the premier terminal across the blue channel stood a gleaming, navy-and-gold *Majestic Cruise Line* ship, its twin funnels shining in the Florida sun.

We didn't turn into the *Majestic* terminal. Instead, Mom directed Dad toward Pier 3, where a boxy, bargain-rate mass-market ship called the *M/S Sunward Tropics* was loading passengers.

By four o'clock that afternoon, standing packed shoulder-to-shoulder in bulky orange foam lifejackets out on the humid teak planks of the Deck 4 Boat Promenade for the mandatory twenty-minute safety muster drill—with all of the ship's elevators shut off—I felt the first warning tremor shoot down both of my calves. Beside me,

Katie was leaning almost her entire weight against my right arm just to keep her knees locked. Both of us had lived with mild cerebral palsy since birth, which had always made our balance uneven, but standing on that hot deck before climbing two flights of metal stairs back to our cramped inside cabin left our legs shaking and our arms strangely weak on the brass banisters in a way neither of us had ever felt before.

Dad walked right behind us up every step of the stairwell, one hand braced behind Katie's back and the other steadying my elbow, his brow furrowed with quiet concern as he watched how hard our arms were straining just to pull ourselves up the railing.

Sunday, August 19, 2001, 9:30 AM — Ditching *Captain Barnaby* for the Deck 8 CyberCafé

"Look at the two of you—you're going to be late for the character breakfast!" Mom snapped at nine-twenty on Sunday morning, shoving two neon-yellow *"Camp Sunward Youth"* lanyards and a printed activity sheet into Dad's hand before disappearing out the cabin door toward the Lido Pool Bar. "And I put Katie's name down for the two o'clock beginner ballet and ballroom workshop in the Starlight Lounge!"

Katie stared at the pink dance slip in horror, her fingers tightening around my wrist as the ship rolled gently on its first full day at sea heading toward Nassau.

"Come on," Dad said quietly, his jaw tight as he picked up his canvas backpack—with the Virginia Beach Public Library *Quantum Basic 5.0* book tucked inside—and led Katie and me down the narrow corridor to the elevator. "Let's go see what your mother signed you up for."

Five minutes later, the three of us stood outside the double glass doors of the Starlight Lounge on Deck 6.

Inside, thirty screaming six- and seven-year-olds were banging plastic spoons against paper placemats while accordion music blared from the speakers. Waddling between the tables were two sweaty crew members zipped into bargain-bin polyester foam mascot suits—*Captain Barnaby the Buccaneer Parrot* and *Salty the Starfish*—whose faded fabric looked like it had been pulled out of a carnival dumpster.

At the podium by the door, a twenty-two-year-old youth counselor glanced down at her clipboard—where Mom had written *Prairie, Nathaniel* and *Prairie, Katie*—and then looked up at two sixteen-year-old high schoolers standing side by side in t-shirts and jeans. Her face turned bright red with second-hand embarrassment.

Dad took one look through the glass doors at the foam parrot, looked at Katie's and my mortified faces, and didn't hesitate for half a second.

"Take those yellow lanyards off, kids," Dad said calmly.

Stepping up to the podium, Dad handed the lanyards back to the relieved counselor, drew a clean line through both of our names on the character breakfast roster, and asked her to cross Katie's name off the afternoon ballet workshop sheet as well.

“Where are the computers and the arcade cabinets on this ship?” Dad asked the counselor.

“Deck 8 Midship, sir—right next to the quiet library and card room,” she replied gratefully.

Ten minutes later, sitting side by side in two padded armchairs inside the air-conditioned quiet of the Deck 8 CyberCafé overlooking the deep blue Atlantic, Katie and I finally exhaled. Dad swiped his cabin card to buy two hours of desktop terminal time, pulled the thick, mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook out of his bag, and set it open on the desk right between our keyboards.

While Mom spent the entire Sunday at sea up at the pool bar, the three of us spent the afternoon right there by the ocean windows—Katie pointing out how to nest `For...Next` loops on the screen, my fingers typing the syntax into the editor, and Dad sitting right beside us smiling with genuine pride.

Part 2: Part 2: The Nassau Pier, Guest Services, & The Last Straw

Date: 2001-08-22 at 14:00 America/Puerto_Rico

Monday–Wednesday, August 20–22, 2001 — The Nassau Pier & The Honest Question

“Hold onto my arm, Nate—don’t look down at the concrete,” Katie breathed against my shoulder as the ninety-two-degree Bahamas sun beat straight down onto the endless gray concrete expanse of Prince George Wharf in Nassau on Monday morning.

Ahead of us, Mom was already a hundred yards down the pier, marching briskly toward the duty-free liquor stores and open-air bars along Bay Street without once looking back to see where her children were. Halfway between the ship’s gangway and the terminal gate, my right knee buckled without warning. When Katie tried to catch my weight with both hands, her own wrists gave out, and both of us nearly went down onto the hot concrete before Dad caught us under the arms and guided us onto a shaded wooden bench beside the port tram stop.

“Neither of you is walking another step in this heat,” Dad said firmly, kneeling down to check our trembling ankles before flagging down the port courtesy shuttle and hiring an air-conditioned island van driver to take just the three of us over the bridge to the step-free underwater glass aquarium tunnel on Paradise Island.

Over the next forty-eight hours—as the ship steamed south from the Bahamas toward Charlotte Amalie in St. Thomas and Philipsburg in St. Maarten—the gap between what Mom wanted and what our bodies could handle grew wider by the hour. Every time the ship rolled in the Caribbean swell, walking the long metal passageways felt like wading through wet cement, while Mom spent every afternoon running up the cabin bar tab and complaining whenever she passed us that Katie wasn’t attending the ship’s dance classes.

On Wednesday afternoon, Dad collected Katie and me outside the Deck 8 arcade, led us to a quiet, shaded alcove of deck chairs, and looked straight at the two of us.

“Please be honest,” Dad asked quietly. “Are you two not enjoying the cruise?”

When Katie and I looked at each other and struggled to come up with an answer, Dad leaned forward and rested his hands on his knees.

“I want to let you both in on how I feel,” Dad said earnestly. “Katie, this especially goes for you. I watched you teach your brother the *Quantum Basic* programming that I am learning in school at CCHR, and I am absolutely encouraging both of you to keep at it if you both like it. I see that your mother is trying to talk you into being a ballerina, but I get that you don’t want to.”

“I don’t have the balance to dance,” Katie said honestly, looking down at her sneakers. Mom still refused to accept that we had cerebral palsy—let alone whatever was making our arms and legs grow weaker this summer—insisting she saw two completely healthy kids. “I like this coding thing.”

“And I am encouraging you with this coding thing… I am encouraging both of you,” Dad said warmly.

“I didn’t appreciate that Mom tried booking us on the kid stuff,” I added, thinking back to the foam parrot mascot at Sunday morning’s breakfast door. “Katie and I are sixteen and already in high school, and I don’t want to meet the characters. It’s not even the characters that little kids want to meet, because it’s not *Majestic Cruise Line*! I want to play the computer games.”

“I get it,” Dad said, nodding firmly. He took a deep breath, his expression turning solemn. “There is something else I wanted to confide in both of you, and that is Mom’s drinking issue. Our next stop will be the front counter where I want to attempt to cut off the flow of alcohol to your mother.”

2:45 PM — Cutting Off the Flow at the Front Counter

The process at the Purser’s Desk in the Deck 5 Atrium Lobby seemed to drag on forever, and Katie and I found a padded seat across the lobby while we waited for Dad to be finished.

Because every bar on the ship operated on cashless plastic stateroom keycards—and because Dad’s *Anchor Federal Credit Union* card was the sole payment method guaranteeing our cabin’s Master Folio—Dad had the authority as the primary account holder to revoke all charging privileges on Mom’s keycard and have the Watch Purser place a mandatory alcohol cut-off flag on her passenger ID across the ship’s point-of-sale network.

When Dad finally walked back over to our bench, he held out three plastic cabin keycards, each newly stamped with a small holographic fountain-cup sticker.

“I bought the three of us a soda package, and we can get sodas and juice every fifteen minutes,” Dad told us. “Your mother is going to be mad, but I don’t care. I am so sorry to both of you that it is turning out like this, but I have to protect both of you.”

Sitting down beside us for a moment, Dad lowered his voice to a quiet whisper.

“I know that you two have decided that you are inseparable, and I am okay with that, and I won’t tell the world about your little secret,” Dad whispered, looking at Katie and me with steady, unconditional protective warmth. “Yes, I know, and I think I’ve known for a while. Just don’t go blabbing to everyone, and be careful with things.”

3:30 PM — The Corridor Breakdown & The Ultimatum

The three of us rode the elevator down to Deck 4 and walked to our stateroom—and to our horror, though not to our surprise, when Dad opened the door, our mother was passed out drunk across the three-cushion convertible sofa that was supposed to unfold into the bed that Katie and I shared at night.

“Oh, I’ve had enough of your mother’s nonsense,” Dad said, pulling the door shut and turning Katie and me right around in the passageway.

We walked a long way through a narrow, windowless maze of identical stateroom hallways—our legs trembling and our feet stumbling against the carpet seams with every roll of the ship—until we finally reached a quiet stairwell seating alcove and sat down on the built-in bench.

Right there under the brass wall sconces, Dad buried his face in his hands and absolutely lost it, breaking down and crying.

Katie and I were completely at a loss for words. Our mental image of Daddy being tough and unbreakable came crashing down all at once, and for the first time in our sixteen years, we were seeing the exhausted, hurting human side of our father.

Katie and I sat close against his sides on the bench and just waited, holding hands because this was something neither of us knew how to respond to.

“I guess it will have to be a cruise for three,” Katie whispered softly to me.

“Yeah, I guess,” I whispered back to my sister. We both looked over at our father, who was the most upset we had ever seen him in our lives. I didn’t even remember crying this hard when taking a bad fall on the pavement, and yet here the three of us were.

“I’ll try my best to handle this. Daddy needs us right now,” Katie whispered, resting her hand on Dad’s arm. “This is going to be a long and painful cruise.”

That was when we heard a screaming rage echoing down the metal hallway toward our alcove.

“The heck was that?” I asked, my heart jumping as a startled Katie looked up beside me.

“Where is my fucking beer?!”

Our mother had woken up from her drunken nap on our sofa, stormed up to the nearest deck bar, discovered that her keycard had been cut off at the register, and tracked us down the corridor—drunkenly screeching profanities at our visibly upset father.

Spotting Katie and me sitting on the alcove bench directly beneath the black dome of the stairwell's ceiling security camera, Mom's bloodshot eyes locked onto us.

"And you two ungrateful brats!" she slurred loudly, staggering forward toward our bench. "I signed you up for the character meet-and-greet and the dance class, and you ditched them and got your father to cut off my card!"

As she lunged toward our bench and swung her arm wildly in my direction, her balance gave out and she missed completely as Dad surged to his feet and stepped squarely between her and the bench, blocking her path in full view of the ceiling security camera.

"Don't you ever raise a hand toward them!" Dad said, his voice turning to iron as he wiped the last trace of tears from his eyes. "I've had enough, and so have the kids. This cruise was supposed to be family time, and the three of us are tired of your drinking. Nathaniel, Katie, and I are giving you a choice right now: us, or the alcohol."

Mom glared at us and slurred something bitter that none of us could even understand.

"Message received," Dad said flatly. "You pick the bottle over your husband and children."

Turning his back on her, Dad looked down at Katie and me and reached out both hands to help us stand up as our mother drunkenly stumbled away down the hall.

"Come on, you two," Dad said gently. "I want you to show me what you two would like to do."

As he supported our elbows and led Katie and me away down the passage, Dad made a vow that neither of us would ever forget.

"I'm making both of you a promise: I want to be a dad, and I want you both to help guide me through this," Dad said quietly. "It will be painful, but your mother does not seem to want to be a mom. I'm sorry, but I have to do right by both of you."

Holding onto Dad's arms as our exhausted legs shook beneath us, the three of us stumbled through what felt like an endless hallway of cabins until we finally stumbled out into the bright light of the lobby.

Part 3: Part 3: Stateroom 6004, The Loaner Wheelchairs, & Pizza for Three on the Aft Deck

Date: 2001-08-23 at 18:30 America/Puerto_Rico

Wednesday, August 22, 2001, 4:15 PM — Domestic Separation, The Brig, & Two Manual Wheelchairs

"My kids can barely stand up after walking down that Deck 4 corridor, and my wife is screaming profanities at us in the passageway," Dad told the Chief Purser flatly as the three of us reached the front counter in the Atrium Lobby, my knees trembling so

badly that I had both hands braced against the marble counter edge while Katie leaned against my side. “I am not putting my son and daughter back in Stateroom 4118 with her tonight. I don’t want her in the cabin with us anymore.”

The Chief Purser glanced down at the black security radio clipped to his lapel, took one look at Dad’s raw, red-rimmed eyes and one look at Katie and me struggling to stay upright on our feet, and immediately picked up a brass master key.

“Deck 4 Security just radioed up after reviewing the stairwell alcove security camera feed, Mr. Prairie,” the Chief Purser said quietly. “Our camera recorded your wife’s outburst in the corridor and her attempt to swing at your son on the bench before you stepped in. We hold two wheelchair-accessible contingency staterooms right off the Deck 6 midship elevators for medical and family safety emergencies. I am placing a confidential Domestic Separation Flag on your manifest right now and moving you, Nathaniel, and Katie into Stateroom 6004. Only your three soda-package keycards will open that door, and our staff is strictly prohibited from disclosing your new cabin number to your wife.”

Dad let out a long breath of pure relief, then glanced down at Katie’s shaking ankles and mine.

“Is there any chance the ship has two manual wheelchairs my twins can use for the rest of the cruise?” Dad asked, looking back at Katie and me to make sure we agreed.

Both Katie and I nodded immediately. Neither of us cared what strangers on a cruise ship thought—we were exhausted from fighting our own legs every time we crossed a deck.

“Consider it done, sir,” the Chief Purser replied. “I’ll have the Medical Center bring two folding *SwiftChair* manual wheelchairs straight up to Stateroom 6004 while our stewards transfer your bags and your library books from Deck 4.”

By five o’clock that afternoon, Dad, Katie, and I were safely upstairs inside Stateroom 6004—a wide, quiet room five steps from the elevator lobby with a clean double sofa bed that unfolded without a single obstacle and two folding manual wheelchairs waiting by the door.

At seven-fifteen that evening, while Katie and I were sitting together on the sofa bed reading Dad’s *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book, a polite knock sounded on our cabin door. When Dad opened it, the Chief Purser stood in the corridor with a clipboard under his arm.

“I wanted to check on you and the twins in person, Mr. Prairie, and let you know that you won’t have to worry about running into your wife on the decks for the rest of the voyage,” the Chief Purser told Dad evenly, his voice carrying clearly to where Katie and I sat. “About an hour ago, Mrs. Prairie returned to Stateroom 4118, found your luggage gone, and came down to the Atrium Lobby after her keycard was declined at the Lido Bar. When we refused to disclose your new cabin number or unblock her alcohol privileges, she tried to climb over the Purser’s counter and swung a fist at one of our Security officers. The Staff Captain has placed her in the ship’s brig down on Deck 2.”

Katie’s hand tightened around mine on the sofa cushion as we listened.

“Because we have already cleared our final Caribbean port of call and are steaming north,” the Chief Purser continued, handing Dad a thick, sealed manila envelope, “she will remain in security custody until we dock at Port Canaveral on Saturday morning, where she will be escorted off the vessel and handed a permanent lifetime ban from *Sunward Cruise Lines*. Inside this envelope is a certified copy of our Shipboard Security Incident Report along with a duplicate VHS tape from the Deck 4 stairwell security camera documenting the 3:30 PM corridor incident, in case your family attorney in Virginia needs official documentation. I also want to assure you, Nathaniel, and Katie that your names are completely clear—none of the three of you are excluded from sailing with us in the future.”

Dad thanked him quietly and closed the door. Mom had managed to get herself banned from a cruise line yet again—not that Dad, Katie, or I ever wanted to set foot on a cruise ship again in the first place.

Thursday, August 23, 2001, 6:30 PM — Pizza & Soda Refills on the Aft Deck

“Two pepperoni slices, two extra-cheese slices, and three fifteen-minute fountain refills—two colas and an orange juice,” Dad announced with a genuine smile on Thursday evening as he set a steaming stainless-steel pizza platter and three tall plastic tumblers down on our round table out on the open wooden aft deck.

Sitting side by side in our two ship-provided folding manual wheelchairs right at the back rail of Deck 9, watching the white foaming wake of the ship stretch out across the turquoise Caribbean Sea under a golden-orange sunset, Katie and I reached across the space between our wheelchair armrests and laced our fingers together.

Inside the main dining rooms tonight was Captain’s Formal Night, where hundreds of passengers were crammed into noisy banquet halls in stiff suits and high heels. Out here on the breezy fantail deck, wearing comfortable t-shirts and jeans with zero pain in our calves or knees thanks to the manual wheelchairs, the last two days of the voyage had finally become what Katie had whispered in the corridor alcove: a peaceful cruise for three.

“How do the chairs feel?” Dad asked softly, pulling his deck chair right up beside our wheels and picking up a slice of pizza.

“So much better, Dad,” Katie said, leaning her head briefly against my shoulder as she took a sip from her straw. “My legs aren’t shaking at all.”

“Mine either,” I agreed, looking down at our three soda-sticker keycards resting together on the table next to Dad’s library copy of *Quantum Basic 5.0*. For the first time all week, nobody was yelling, nobody was trying to force Katie to dance or shove us into a room with foam parrot mascots, and as the warm ocean breeze blew past the stern rail, the three of us talked for two straight hours about the programs we were going to write when we got home to Virginia Beach.

Part 4: Part 4: Back on Dry Land & The Twelve-Hour Drive Up I-95

Date: 2001-08-25 at 08:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 25, 2001, 8:30 AM — Back on Dry Land

"Nathaniel. Katie. I'm sorry that your first cruise was wrecked, and somehow I want to make it up to both of you," Dad said earnestly as two crew members helped us transfer out of the ship's loaner wheelchairs onto the gray cloth back bench seat of our Holt sedan at the Port Canaveral pickup curb. Resting a steady hand on each of our shoulders through the open door, Dad continued, "Here is what we will do: neither one of you wanted to go on that cruise, but your mother insisted. I want to finish school at CCHR so that I can do a better job at being a dad without having to worry about money as much."

Before Katie or I could answer him, an angry screech tore across the concrete baggage drop from behind us.

"You! You told the ship to stop my drinks!"

Looking through the open rear doorway, I saw our mother being escorted out of the customs terminal doors by two *Sunward Cruise Lines* security officers after being released from the ship's brig, clutching a folded white sheet of permanent lifetime ban paperwork in her fist. Her face was flushed dark red in the morning Florida heat as she stormed up to the rear fender of our car.

Every muscle in Dad's jaw tightened as he straightened up beside our open door and looked at her.

"If we were anywhere near Hampton Roads right now, Brenda, I would hand you twenty dollars for a bus fare and leave you standing on this curb," Dad told her, his voice as cold and flat as steel. "The only reason I am unlocking this front door is because we are seven hundred miles from Virginia. Get in the front passenger seat, and don't say a single word to the kids for the next twelve hours. The second this car pulls into our driveway in Virginia Beach, you are packing your bags and getting out of our house."

Without waiting for her to reply, Dad closed our rear door securely, walked around to the driver's side, and pulled out of Port Canaveral toward Interstate 95 North.

12:15 PM — Exit 94 Near Savannah, Georgia: The Gas Pump, The Restrooms, & Brenda's First Angle

For the first three and a half hours heading north out of Florida across the Georgia state line, the inside of the car was dead silent except for the hum of the tires and the air conditioner. In the back seat, Katie and I sat pressed shoulder-to-shoulder with our inner hands laced together and Dad's mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook resting across our knees.

Just past noon, the low-fuel chime dinged on the dashboard, and Dad signaled right at Exit 94 near Savannah, pulling under the canopy of a highway travel plaza so we could get gas and use the restrooms.

That stop was when the physical reality of leaving the ship hit Katie and me all over again.

On Thursday and Friday aboard the *Sunward Tropics*, we had rolled everywhere in the Medical Center's two folding loaner wheelchairs. Those wheelchairs belonged to the ship, which meant they were still back at Port Canaveral. When Dad opened our rear door beside Pump 6 and I swung my sneakers out onto the ninety-degree Georgia concrete, my knees and calves trembled so violently that I had to grab the roof frame with both hands just to keep from sliding onto the pavement. Beside me, when Katie tried to push herself up off the bench cushion, the strength in her right forearm gave out halfway up, and she gasped softly as she sank back against the seat.

Up front, Mom didn't even glance back at our door. She slammed the front passenger door shut and marched briskly across the concrete apron toward the air-conditioned travel store restrooms on her own.

Dad saw us struggling immediately. Leaving the gas nozzle clicking in the tank, he stepped right between Katie and me, braced his left arm firmly around Katie's waist and his right hand under my elbow, and took half of our weight onto his own shoulders.

"Take your time, kids—I've got both of you," Dad murmured close to our ears as he walked us slowly, step by shuffling step, across the hot pavement and up the curb ramp to the restroom hallway. He stood waiting right between the men's and women's doors until both of us came back out, then supported us all the way back to the back seat of the Holt before topping off the tank and paying at the window.

When Mom finally strolled back out of the convenience store carrying a bottle of water and buckled herself into the front passenger seat, her furious scowl from Port Canaveral was suddenly replaced by self-pity. As Dad checked in the rearview mirror to make sure Katie and I were buckled securely into our back-seat shoulder belts, shifted into drive, and merged back onto I-95 North, Mom launched into a bitter, non-stop tirade about how "unfairly" she had been treated down in the ship's brig.

"David, honey, look—let's be reasonable now that we're off that awful boat," Mom complained, turning slightly toward him in the front seat. "Do you have any idea how terrible life in a cruise ship brig actually is, or what I just went through for sixty-two straight hours? It was completely unfair! That purser had it out for me from the moment we boarded, and those security guards treated me like a common criminal over a couple of drinks!"

In the back seat, Katie and I glanced at each other and squeezed hands as Mom kept going, oblivious to the way Dad's jaw was clenching harder with every word out of her mouth.

"They put wrist restraints on me and marched me down a steel freight elevator to the Deck 2 crew corridor below the waterline, right on top of the diesel engine room!" Mom ranted, her voice rising with indignation. "They confiscated my cabin card, my wristwatch, my belt, and even my shoes! For two and a half days I was locked inside a windowless steel box that vibrated twenty-four hours a day from the ship's engines. No porthole, no clock, no television, no pillow—just a hard vinyl mat bolted to the steel floor with a stiff Velcro blanket, an institutional stainless-steel toilet welded to the sink in the corner, and a blinding fluorescent ceiling light with a security camera staring at me that never turned off once!"

Beside me, Katie leaned her head close to my shoulder. Both of us could see the muscles in Dad's neck and shoulders stiffening against the driver's backrest. Mom thought she was winning sympathy, when in reality every single complaint she made was hardening Dad's resolve like poured concrete.

"And the food!" Mom went on, gesturing with her water bottle. "While the three of you were upstairs doing whatever you wanted, they wouldn't even let me have a soda! Every four hours the ship's doctor or some nurse slid open the metal slot in the door to take my blood pressure and hand me paper cones of lukewarm tap water and salt packets while my head was splitting open! Three times a day a guard shoved a paper plate of bland crew-galley mush through the slot with a bendable plastic spoon, and every fifteen minutes day and night a guard slid the peephole open to write on a clipboard! Then yesterday afternoon they had the nerve to tell me that stewards had packed my clothes out of Cabin 4118 with red security tape and handed me a lifetime ban! I've been punished enough, David—there's no reason to talk crazy about me packing bags when we get home."

Katie looked at me and gave a tiny, unmistakable shake of her head. *Every argument she makes,* Katie's eyes said to mine, *just weakens her case even more.*

I thought the exact same thing. For sixty-two hours down on Deck 2, Mom hadn't spent a single minute worrying about her sixteen-year-old twins or her husband—she had only cared about her confiscated watch, her crew-galley trays, and her cut-off beer tab.

From the back bench seat, I watched Dad's knuckles turn white against the top of the steering wheel. In the rearview mirror, his eyes met mine and Katie's for a brief, steady second before he answered without even looking at Mom.

"You swung a fist at a ship security officer because they wouldn't serve you beer at four o'clock in the afternoon, Brenda," Dad said in a low, gravelly voice that carried clearly to the back seat. "That headache you had down on Deck 2 was sixty-two hours of forced sobriety. And while you were passed out drunk on the kids' sofa bed before security locked you up, I had to hold our sixteen-year-old son and daughter up by their elbows because their legs and arms were giving out on them. Just ten minutes ago at that gas pump, neither one of them could stand up out of the back seat without leaning on me, and you walked right past them to the store without looking back once. That brig wasn't unfair. It was the consequence of who you've chosen to be."

4:45 PM — Rocky Mount, North Carolina: Drive-Thru Dinner & Cementing the Lawyer Decision

By quarter to five that afternoon, as the green highway signs ticked past Fayetteville and into Rocky Mount, North Carolina, the three of us were starving and needed another restroom stop.

After Dad helped Katie and me carefully in and out of the roadside rest-area bathrooms just off the exit—where my wrists shook so badly I could barely push the heavy metal restroom door open by myself—Dad didn't make us walk inside a crowded highway sit-down restaurant and try to carry plastic food trays on trembling arms. Instead, he pulled the Holt sedan straight into the drive-thru lane of

a *Penny's* hamburger restaurant next to the interstate ramp, ordered four cheeseburger meals, and handed a warm white paper bag of cheeseburgers and fries back to Katie and me before merging back onto the highway.

Buckled safely into our three-point shoulder seatbelts side by side on the gray cloth rear bench seat as the pine trees and green *I-95 NORTH* signs rolled past our rear window, Katie held the white paper *Penny's* bag on her lap while Dad's mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook rested open across mine, with our inner hands clasped tightly together on the cushion between us.

Up in the front passenger seat, as Mom finished her sandwich, I heard her abandon the brig complaints and try a second angle—cold financial bargaining.

"Think about this logically for two seconds, David," Mom said, her voice sharp and calculating in the quiet car. "You're taking classes at CCHR. How exactly do you think you're going to pay the house note in Virginia Beach, buy groceries, finish your degree, and take care of two sixteen-year-olds all by yourself without my income? Look—I'll cut back to drinking only on Friday and Saturday nights. We can put this behind us and go back to normal on Monday."

Beside me in the back seat, Katie squeezed my left hand with her right. Neither of us was even afraid that Dad would give in anymore—watching the back of Dad's shoulders, both of us could tell that Mom was digging her own grave deeper with every sentence.

"She doesn't get it at all," Katie whispered so softly that only I could hear her over the hum of the highway tires.

"Not even a little," I whispered back, looking down at our joined hands between my open *Quantum Basic* book and her lunch bag. Since the day we were born, Katie and I had been each other's anchor, best friend, and safe harbor—and in the lifelong bond the two of us shared, there was simply no room left for someone as bitter, selfish, and mean as our mother. All we needed was each other and our dad.

Up front, I watched Dad slowly set his cup into the center console holder, glance briefly toward the passenger seat, and speak in a calm, ironclad voice I had never heard from him in my life.

"Thank you for saying that out loud, Brenda—because if I had one percent of doubt left about seeking a lawyer's advice when we get home, every argument you've made since Florida just erased it," Dad told her evenly. "You spent three hours complaining about a steel bunk in the brig, and now you're bargaining to drink on weekends—and you still haven't asked Nathaniel or Katie a single time in eight hours why their legs and arms are failing them. I don't care if I have to work double shifts around my CCHR classes to pay the bills. First thing Monday morning at eight-thirty, I am calling a divorce lawyer to file for divorce and full custody of the twins, and my very next call is going to be to Dr. Chen's office to get both of them examined. We are never going back to 'normal.'"

Mom opened her mouth, saw the look on Dad's face, and snapped her jaw shut without another word for the rest of North Carolina and Virginia.

9:15 PM — Home in Virginia Beach: Packing the Bags

At nine-fifteen that night, after more than twelve hours on the road, the headlights of our Holt sedan finally swept across our driveway in Virginia Beach.

Before touching a single suitcase in the trunk, Dad walked around to our rear door, helped Katie and me out of the back seat, and supported both of us up the front steps and straight inside to the living room sofa, propping two throw pillows behind our backs and setting his *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book on the coffee table within easy reach.

Then, true to his word from Port Canaveral, Dad walked back out into the front foyer, folded his arms across his chest, and stood watch at the bottom of the stairs for forty-five straight minutes while Brenda packed her suitcases, dragged them out the front door to her car, and backed out of the driveway.

When Dad clicked the front deadbolt shut and walked into the living room to check on us, our house was finally, mercifully peaceful.

Part 5: Part 5: Monday Morning in Virginia Beach — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

Date: 2001-08-27 at 10:15 America/New_York

Monday, August 27, 2001, 10:15 AM — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

“Squeeze my fingers as hard as you can, Nathaniel, and hold it for five seconds,” Dr. Evelyn Chen instructed gently inside Exam Room 2 of her Virginia Beach family practice clinic on Monday morning.

Sitting side by side on the crinkly white paper of the padded exam table in our t-shirts and jeans, Katie and I kept our inner hands laced tightly together between our knees while I reached my left hand out to squeeze Dr. Chen’s fingers.

Earlier that morning at eight-thirty, while Katie and I sat at the kitchen table eating cereal with the sealed *Sunward Cruise Lines* manila envelope resting beside the napkin holder, we had listened as Dad stood by the kitchen wall phone and kept the first half of his highway vow—calling a family law and divorce attorney’s office off Independence Boulevard.

When Dad told the attorney on the line that he had a certified Shipboard Security Incident Report and a duplicate VHS security camera tape from Deck 4 showing Brenda’s corridor outburst and her attempt to swing at me on the bench over the character meet-and-greet, we watched a wave of relief wash across Dad’s face. Hanging up the receiver, Dad had turned to Katie and me and explained what the lawyer had just told him: under Virginia law, the one-year separation waiting period only applied to no-fault divorces. Because the ship’s security camera had caught her attempt to strike a minor child and her subsequent detention in the brig, Dad qualified to file immediately on fault grounds of cruelty and reasonable apprehension of bodily hurt—allowing the lawyer to petition the Virginia Beach court right away for sole custody of the two of us, exclusive possession of our house, and a protective order without waiting a single year.

The moment he finished writing down our afternoon appointment time with the lawyer, Dad dialed Dr. Chen, our Primary Care Physician, and explained how badly our arms and legs had been giving out on the cruise and at the Interstate 95 rest stops. Dr. Chen's nurse had told him to bring both of us straight in at ten o'clock.

For the first two seconds, my grip held around Dr. Chen's fingers—and then, no matter how hard I concentrated, the strength in my forearm and wrist drained away like water through a sieve. When Dr. Chen tested Katie's grip, her shoulder resistance, and the dorsiflexion in both of our ankles, the exact same drop-off happened.

Dr. Chen stepped back, slipped her reflex hammer into the pocket of her white coat, and looked gravely at Dad, who was standing protectively right beside us.

"David," Dr. Chen said quietly, "bringing them in immediately after you got back from Florida was the exact right call."

"They've had mild cerebral palsy since they were little," Dad said, his hand resting warmly on Katie's shoulder. "Brenda always ignored it and acted like they were two completely typical kids, so at first I assumed the ship's movement was just aggravating their balance. Why are both their arms and their legs getting worse at sixteen?"

"Because cerebral palsy does not degenerate over time," Dr. Chen answered clearly, looking from Dad to Katie and me with deep compassion. "Cerebral palsy is a static, non-progressive condition. When sixteen-year-old twins begin losing measurable motor strength in both their lower extremities and their upper extremities over the course of a single summer, something else is happening."

Beside me on the exam table, Katie squeezed my fingers with every ounce of strength left in her hand, and I squeezed right back.

"I'm ordering a full neuromuscular blood panel, nerve conduction studies, and a genetic workup this morning," Dr. Chen continued gently, picking up her chart clipboard. "Until those test results come back and tell us exactly what condition we are dealing with, I need all three of you to prepare yourselves for the reality of what I'm seeing in their muscle tone today. When it comes to walking, Nathaniel and Katie are on borrowed time. Eventually, neither of them is going to be able to walk."

The quiet exam room seemed to hold its breath around those words—*on borrowed time*.

Yet as I looked sideways at my twin sister, and felt Dad's steady, unwavering arm wrap around both of our shoulders at once, the fear didn't break us. Whatever the test results showed when they came back from the lab, Mom's screaming was gone, Daddy was standing right beside us, and Katie and I were going to face every single mile of it together.

Junior Year at Northwood High & The Prognosis

Part 1: Part 1: The Fault-Grounds Filing, The Protective Order, & Junior Year at Northwood High School

Date: 2001-09-04 at 11:40 America/New_York

Monday, August 27, 2001, 2:00 PM — The Lawyer's Office off Independence Boulevard

"Timestamp fifteen-thirty-two and eighteen seconds," family law attorney Arthur Vance read aloud in his quiet, wood-paneled conference room off Independence Boulevard, pressing the pause button on his office VCR remote so the grainy black-and-white frame from the *M/S Sunward Tropics* Deck 4 stairwell camera froze on the television screen.

Sitting side by side on the leather sofa across from Mr. Vance's desk with our inner hands clasped tightly together, Katie and I looked at the frozen image on the screen. Right there beneath the ceiling camera's timestamp—`AUG 22 2001 15:32:18 CAM-04B`—was our mother lunging toward our alcove bench with her arm raised, and Dad standing like a shield squarely between her and the two of us.

"Mr. Prairie, in twenty-four years of practicing family law in Virginia Beach, I have rarely seen a cleaner, more airtight evidentiary packet," Mr. Vance said, setting the remote down beside the Staff Captain's notarized *Shipboard Security Incident Report* and permanent lifetime exclusion notice. "Normally in Virginia, when minor children are involved, a couple has to live separate and apart for one full year before filing for a no-fault divorce. You do not have to wait a single day."

Across from us, Dad leaned forward in his chair, his hands folded on the edge of the mahogany table.

"How fast can we get the court orders in place so Brenda can't come back to the house or show up at their high school when classes start next week?" Dad asked.

"This afternoon," Mr. Vance answered firmly. "Because the ship's security camera captured her attempting to strike sixteen-year-old Nathaniel while intoxicated—and because the ship's brig and medical logs corroborate every word—we are filing a fault-based Complaint for Divorce on grounds of cruelty and reasonable apprehension of bodily hurt under Virginia Code Section 20-91(A)(6) before the Circuit Court clerk's office closes at four o'clock. Alongside it, I am walking an emergency *pendente lite* petition and family protective order straight in to the duty judge."

Mr. Vance counted the points off on his fingers so Katie and I could follow every step.

"First, you get immediate temporary sole legal and physical custody of Nathaniel and Katie," Mr. Vance said. "Second, you get exclusive use and possession of the marital home in Virginia Beach—meaning you are legally authorized to change every lock on the doors tonight, and Brenda cannot set foot on the property. Third, the protective order bars her from coming within five hundred feet of the twins or

setting foot on the campus of Northwood High School. And fourth, because fault grounds of cruelty bar an offending spouse from receiving alimony under Virginia law, she won't get a dime of spousal support."

Beside me on the leather sofa, Katie let out a long, quiet breath and leaned her shoulder against mine. That evening before dinner, Dad bought three brass deadbolt kits at the hardware store, changed every lock on our front, back, and garage doors, and handed the shiny new keys to Katie and me.

Tuesday, September 4, 2001, 11:40 AM — Junior Year at Northwood High School

"We actually pulled it off, Nate—fourth-block lunch and study hall together every single day," Katie said with a relieved smile the Tuesday after Labor Day as the two of us eased down side by side onto the bench of a quiet, sunlit corner table near the tall windows of the Northwood High School cafeteria.

Back in July, when we had given up half of our mornings to sit through high-school summer school and knock out a required academic credit early, this exact forty-five-minute sanctuary in the middle of our Junior year schedule was what we had worked for. Earlier that morning at seven-forty-five, Dad had walked into the Northwood High main office with us to hand-deliver a certified copy of the Virginia Beach judge's custody and protective orders to the principal's secretary, removing Brenda's name from our emergency contact cards for good.

Yet as grateful as Katie and I were to be sitting together with our brown paper lunch bags, juice boxes, and our spiral *Quantum Basic* notebook open on the tabletop between us, getting through the first three class periods of eleventh grade had been a sobering wake-up call for our bodies.

Even without the roll of a cruise ship beneath our feet, the long linoleum hallways and concrete stairwells of Northwood High School had pushed our legs and arms to the brink before noon. Halfway up the B-Wing stairs to second-period Chemistry, my left calf had cramped and given out so suddenly that I would have gone down on the steps if Katie hadn't grabbed my belt loop—and when she tried to pull my weight upright against the handrail, her own right wrist and forearm had trembled so violently that she dropped her binder across the landing. By the time we reached the cafeteria doors at eleven-forty, my thighs felt like lead weights and Katie's fingers were shaking so hard that I had to help her pinch open the top of her straw wrapper.

Reaching across the table between our lunch bags, I laced my right fingers through Katie's left hand and rested our joined hands flat on the cool laminate tabletop so neither of our wrists had to work to hold them up.

"How bad are your legs shaking right now?" I asked her quietly beneath the chatter of the cafeteria.

"From my knees down to my ankles," Katie admitted softly, her thumb brushing against the back of my hand as she glanced down at the event-loop diagram in my notebook. "And my right shoulder still hurts from carrying my backpack down the upstairs hall. Dr. Chen said our lab and nerve-conduction results come back next week, right?"

“Friday afternoon,” I nodded, squeezing her hand gently. “Whatever those tests say, we’ve got Dad on our side now, and we’ve got this lunch table every day. We’ll get through eleventh grade together.”

Part 2: Part 2: The Test Results & Dr. Chen’s Prognosis for Our Arms and Legs

Date: 2001-09-14 at 15:30 America/New_York

Friday, September 14, 2001, 3:30 PM — The Prognosis for Our Legs and Our Arms

“The genetic sequencing and nerve-conduction studies from Norfolk finally arrived by ground courier this morning, and they gave us the missing piece of the puzzle,” Dr. Evelyn Chen said gently on Friday afternoon, looking across her wooden consultation desk at Dad, Katie, and me with the thick manila lab folder open in front of her.

Outside the tall venetian blinds of Dr. Chen’s office—just like at Northwood High School and along every block of Independence Boulevard we had driven past after the final bell—the American flag in the medical plaza courtyard hung quietly at half-staff in the late-summer breeze.

It was Friday, September 14, 2001—the National Day of Prayer and Remembrance. Three days earlier, on Tuesday morning, Katie and I had been sitting in our second-period classrooms at Northwood High when the principal’s voice came over the intercom with the news of what had happened in New York, at the Pentagon up in Northern Virginia, and in Pennsylvania. In a military and naval community like Virginia Beach—where half of our classmates had mothers and fathers stationed at Naval Station Norfolk, Little Creek, or Oceana—the entire school had fallen into a hushed, prayerful silence. Dad had left the CCHR campus immediately that Tuesday morning to pick Katie and me up early, and for the past three evenings the three of us had sat close together on our living-room sofa, grateful beyond words simply to be safe under one roof. Because every civilian flight in the country had been grounded on Tuesday, our out-of-state genetic reference panel had been rerouted by highway courier into Norfolk, arriving on Dr. Chen’s desk just before noon today.

Sitting side by side in the two padded visitor chairs in front of Dr. Chen’s desk in the solemn quiet of that Friday afternoon, Katie and I held hands tightly across the space between our armrests while Dad sat right beside Katie with his hand resting steadily on her shoulder.

“When you two were toddlers,” Dr. Chen explained, speaking directly to Katie and me as well as to Dad, “your clumsiness and uneven balance were diagnosed as mild spastic diplegic cerebral palsy. Because mild CP is non-progressive—and because your mother always dismissed any new symptoms at your annual checkups—nobody realized that your early balance issues were also masking a second, genetic condition that both of you inherited as fraternal twins: a juvenile-onset progressive axonal motor neuropathy.”

Dad leaned forward slightly, his eyes fixed on Dr. Chen. “What does that mean for their legs and their arms, Evelyn? Give it to the three of us straight.”

Dr. Chen nodded solemnly and folded her hands atop the chart.

“Let’s start with their legs,” Dr. Chen said clearly. “In this type of hereditary axonal neuropathy, the longest motor nerves in the body—the ones running from the spine all the way down to the feet, ankles, calves, and quadriceps—lose their electrical signal amplitude first, and the adolescent growth spurt at fifteen and sixteen accelerates that loss dramatically. Right now, Nathaniel and Katie are using every ounce of reserve muscle strength they have just to walk across a hallway at Northwood High School. As I warned you after the cruise, their ability to walk is on borrowed time. Within the next six to eighteen months—well before they graduate high school—neither of their legs will be able to support their body weight safely, and both of them will transition to using wheelchairs full-time.”

Katie’s fingers tightened around mine between our chairs, and I squeezed her hand right back so she knew I wasn’t letting go.

“And what about our arms, Dr. Chen?” Katie asked, her voice quiet but steady. “At school last week, my wrist and shoulder gave out just trying to hold my binder on the stairs. Are we going to lose the ability to type on a computer?”

Dr. Chen’s expression softened with immediate, heartfelt reassurance.

“That is the most important part of your prognosis for your arms, Katie,” Dr. Chen answered warmly. “In your upper extremities, the neuropathy is causing progressive weakness and rapid muscle fatigue in your shoulders, biceps, forearms, and grip endurance. That means neither of you should be carrying heavy school backpacks, lifting heavy objects, or trying to push standard manual wheelchair rims down long school corridors—because pushing manual wheels all day will burn out your wrists and forearms and leave your hands shaking.”

She tapped a printed medical accommodation packet beside her chart.

“However,” Dr. Chen continued, looking straight at Katie and me, “if we protect your upper bodies from heavy lifting and manual pushing right now, your fine finger dexterity at a keyboard will remain intact for years to come. You will still be able to type, write computer code, use a mouse, and hold hands—as long as your forearms are resting on padded desk supports and you are typing on low-force keyboards.”

A wave of pure, unmistakable relief washed through my chest, and beside me I felt Katie’s shoulders drop an inch as she exhaled. We were going to lose the ability to walk—and we weren’t going to be able to lift heavy things or push ourselves long distances—but we weren’t going to lose our coding, and we weren’t going to lose each other.

“Here is what I am ordering starting Monday morning,” Dr. Chen said, sliding three signed forms across the desk toward Dad. “First, I have signed a formal Section 504 Medical Mobility Plan for Northwood High School: elevator keys for both twins, a second set of textbooks kept in every classroom so neither of them ever carries a heavy backpack again, and five extra minutes of passing time between blocks so they are never jostled in crowded hallways. Second, I am referring both of them to the seating clinic for compact, portable power wheelchairs with right-hand armrest joysticks that can disassemble to fit in a car trunk—so they can glide down the hallway with one finger on a joystick without ever straining their wrists on manual push rims.”

Dad picked up the signed forms with a steady hand and looked at Katie and me with deep, unwavering love.

“Whatever equipment they need, Evelyn, we’ll get it,” Dad said firmly. Turning to Katie and me, he rested a hand on each of our shoulders. “You two just focus on Junior year, your lunch period together, and your *Quantum Basic* programs. I’ve got the rest.”

Part 3: Part 3: Two Compact Power Wheelchairs in the Trunk, Downsizing to Military Highway, & CVTA Route 15

Date: 2001-10-06 at 13:10 America/New_York

Saturday, October 6, 2001, 1:10 PM — Two Compact Power Wheelchairs in the Trunk & Our New House off Military Highway

“Unclip the two under-seat battery boxes first, pull the quick-release pins to lift both padded seats off their posts, fold the backrests and footrests flat, and set the two compact motorized drive bases side by side in the trunk with two inches to spare under the hinges,” Dad said with a proud grin on the first Saturday of October, wiping his brow as he demonstrated how both of our brand-new **SwiftChair** compact portable power wheelchairs broke down to fit inside the open trunk of our silver-blue **Holt** sedan.

Standing side by side on the concrete driveway of our new rental house with one hand braced against the rear quarter panel of the car and our inner hands clasped together for balance, Katie and I watched Dad practice the disassembly routine he had timed with his wristwatch all morning.

Four days earlier, the seating clinic had delivered the two compact, take-apart power wheelchairs Dr. Chen had prescribed for us—nimble, small-footprint power bases with ten-inch solid drive wheels, under-seat battery packs, and feather-light right-hand armrest joysticks that let us glide down the long hallways of Northwood High School with a gentle nudge of one finger without ever straining our wrists or shoulders on manual hand rims. Because Dr. Chen had documented our progressive axonal motor neuropathy down to the millimeter, Dad’s health insurance had covered ninety percent of the chairs.

What health insurance didn’t cover, however, was a vehicle to carry them assembled.

A full-size conversion van equipped with a hydraulic wheelchair lift or fold-out side ramp cost upwards of thirty-five thousand dollars—an astronomical sum that might as well have been thirty-five million on Dad’s tight budget. Between trying to finish his computer science degree at the **Community College of Hampton Roads**, losing Brenda’s paycheck—meager as her income had been—and getting stuck with the crushing credit card debt from the seven-day Caribbean cruise that Brenda had booked behind his back, Dad was scraping by to make every dollar count.

Thankfully, because the seating clinic had ordered portable take-apart power chairs whose battery packs, seats, and drive bases separated into manageable thirty-five-pound components—and while our legs still had enough borrowed time left to bear weight for a ten-second stand-pivot transfer into the back seat of our family **Holt** sedan—we could still get around by car without a lift van. Whenever we drove

somewhere, Katie and I would roll our compact power chairs right up to the open rear passenger door, switch off our joysticks, hold onto the doorframe and each other, and pivot onto the back bench seat to buckle our three-point seatbelts while Dad broke both chairs down like a pit crew and loaded the bases, battery boxes, and folded seats into the trunk.

Even so, Dad had been completely honest with Katie and me around the kitchen table two weeks earlier when he opened his budget ledger.

Without a second income—and with the cruise credit card bill and legal fees hanging over our heads—we couldn't afford the mortgage on our old two-story house anymore. More importantly, even if we could have paid for it, our old house had fourteen steep wooden stairs leading up to the bedrooms and the only full bathroom—stairs that Dr. Chen had warned us neither Katie nor I would be able to climb safely once our legs gave out for good.

So Dad had put the two-story house up for sale—using the modest equity to wipe out Brenda's cruise debt completely—and spent every evening for two weeks poring over rental listings, Virginia Beach school-zone boundary maps, and printed bus schedules from the **Coastal Virginia Transit Authority**.

What Dad found was a stroke of pure logistical genius: a small, single-story brick ranch house for rent on a quiet side street just off **Military Highway** near the **Indian River Road** intersection, right where Virginia Beach met Norfolk and Chesapeake.

First, the rent was nearly four hundred dollars a month less than our old mortgage, bringing our monthly bills comfortably inside Dad's budget while he finished school at **CCHR**. Second, every single room in the little house—the living room, the eat-in kitchen, the hallway bathroom with its step-in shower grab bars, and both bedrooms—sat on one flat ground floor, with a gentle aluminum ramp Dad had bolted over the two brick front porch steps. Third, because the house sat just inside the western edge of **Northwood High School's** zoned attendance boundary, Katie and I didn't have to change high schools in the middle of our Junior year, and a lift-equipped Virginia Beach school bus could pick us up right at the end of our driveway every weekday morning.

And fourth—the detail Dad was proudest of as he reassembled our two compact power wheelchairs on the driveway, locked the seats onto their posts, and dropped the battery boxes back into place—was what ran right along the massive eight-lane corridor of **US-13 (Military Highway)** at the end of our block.

"Try easing back into your chairs and let's head out to the corner on Military Highway before the one-twenty-five bus gets here," Dad said, closing the trunk lid of the **Holt** sedan and holding up a yellow-highlighted paper pamphlet folded in his hand. "Since **Route 15** stays strictly out on Military Highway and doesn't turn into the neighborhood streets, I want to show you two how fast we can get out to the main road without having to break your power chairs down at all."

Easing off the car fender into our padded wheelchair seats, Katie and I clicked our lap belts shut, pressed the green power buttons on our armrest joysticks, and hummed side by side down the smooth concrete sidewalk behind Dad. In less than three minutes, we turned the corner from our quiet residential block onto the wide

sidewalk bordering **Military Highway and Indian River Road**, where four lanes of northbound traffic and four lanes of southbound traffic roared past a raised center median.

Saturday, October 6, 2001, 1:25 PM — Catching CVTA Route 15 on Eight-Lane Military Highway

“Look at the timetable right here under **Military Hwy. & Indian River Rd.**,” Dad said over the steady hum of eight-lane highway traffic as the three of us stopped beside the metal bus stop post in the crisp October sunshine, unfolding the printed **CVTA Route 15 — *Naval Base Norfolk / Robert Hall Blvd.*** schedule so both Katie and I could read it.

Holding Katie’s left hand with my right hand between our two compact power wheelchairs, I leaned in with my sister to follow the yellow highlighter line Dad had drawn across the grid of numbers.

“Wait a second,” Katie said, her eyes widening as she traced the columns from left to right. “It runs every thirty minutes all day Monday through Saturday?”

“Like clockwork,” Dad smiled, tapping each column with his index finger. “Going northbound up Military Highway, **Route 15** stops right across the highway at **Military Highway and Indian River Road** at `:01` and `:31` past every hour from six-thirty-one in the morning until six-thirty-one at night, and then once an hour until ten-thirty-one. In exactly fourteen minutes—at `:15` and `:45` past the hour—it drops you right at the doors of **Glenrock Mall**, where you can transfer to Routes `20`, `23`, `25`, or `27`, or stay right on **Route 15** past **Glenrock Shopping Center**, **Little Creek Road**, and **Hampton Boulevard** all the way to **Naval Base Norfolk**.”

“And what about going southbound on our side of the road?” I asked, looking at the lower table where Dad had highlighted two alternating rows in yellow and green.

“That’s the best part,” Dad said, pointing to the bold route note printed across the center of the timetable: *On arrival at Old Emerald Creek Rd. and Military Hwy., every other trip will alternate between Robert Hall and Emerald Creek Mall Monday through Saturday.* “Southbound buses leave **Glenrock Mall** at `:15` and `:45` past the hour and get right here to **Military Highway and Indian River Road** ten minutes later, at `:25` and `:55` past every hour. Every bus that stops here at `:25` past the hour—like the `1:25 PM` bus coming down the right-hand lane right now—turns onto the **Emerald Creek Mall** branch and puts us at the mall entrance twenty minutes later at `1:45 PM`. And every bus that stops here at `:55` past the hour goes straight down to **Robert Hall Boulevard** and **Tidewater Square** by `:15` past the next hour.”

Right on cue, signaling across the four southbound lanes of **US-13 (Military Highway)** toward our curb was one of the classic forty-foot high-floor workhorses of the fleet: a `900`-series **Beacon V** transit bus (**Fleet #`914`**) that operated alongside the agency’s high-floor **MetroCoach** buses. Because **Tidewater Regional Transit (`TRT`)** on the Southside and **Peninsula Transit (`PenTran`)** across the harbor had only merged two years earlier in October 1999 to form the **Coastal Virginia Transit Authority (`CVTA`)**, **Bus #`914`** was still wearing its original 1990s **TRT** paint scheme

—a crisp white body banded with horizontal navy-blue and green stripes down its flanks—with a rectangular **CVTA** logo vinyl decal sticker applied right next to the front boarding doors below the **15 EMERALD CREEK MALL** destination sign.

As **Bus #914** hissed to a stop parallel to the concrete curb, the bi-fold front doors swung open. Because the 900-series **Beacon V** was a true high-floor bus whose main passenger deck sat three full feet above the street at the top of a three-step stairwell, there was no sloped ramp. Instead, standing high up on the elevated driver's platform, the uniformed operator pulled the parking brake knob, flipped up the two forward priority benches behind the driver's area, and switched on the **Elevate-U** electro-hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift.

"Afternoon, folks! Welcome aboard **The 15**," the operator called down warmly from the elevated doorway as the three deep front steps flattened into a level horizontal steel elevator platform, telescoped outward on twin vertical hydraulic lift arms with yellow-and-black tubular side handrails, and lowered straight down to rest flat on the concrete sidewalk before dropping the yellow outer safety barrier flap flush against the curb. "Come on onto the elevator platform one at a time—I've got both wheelchair bays folded up and ready for you!"

Katie and I glanced at each other with identical grins. Nobody had to struggle with a car transfer, and Dad didn't have to unclip battery boxes or lift thirty-five-pound power-chair bases into a trunk. Giving Katie's hand a quick squeeze before letting go for thirty seconds, I nudged my right-hand joystick forward and rolled my compact power chair onto the flat horizontal steel platform between the two side handrails first; the outer yellow safety barrier flipped up behind my rear wheels to lock me in, the twin vertical hydraulic arms raised my chair straight up three feet in the air like an elevator to the high interior floor of **Bus #914**, and I backed neatly into the right-hand securement bay. Seconds later, the elevator platform lowered straight back down to the sidewalk for Katie and lifted her power chair right up to the high deck across the aisle from me before folding seamlessly back into three staircase steps so Dad could climb up into the bus and drop our fares into the farebox.

Once the operator had clicked the four-point floor straps onto both of our power-chair frames, the front doors hissed shut and **Bus #914** merged back into the four southbound lanes of Military Highway.

Across the center aisle of the high-floor bus, Katie reached her left hand out over her armrest, and I reached my right hand out to meet hers, our fingers lacing together in the warm afternoon sunlight streaming through the tall transit windows.

"We don't need a thirty-five-thousand-dollar van to go wherever we want, Nate," Katie said softly over the deep diesel rumble of the **Beacon V** engine as we cruised south toward **Emerald Creek Mall**. "Between the school bus on weekdays, breaking our chairs down for the trunk of Dad's car, and **Route 15** out on Military Highway at the end of our block, we've got the whole city back."

"And a house with zero stairs," I agreed, squeezing my sister's hand as Dad smiled at the two of us from the seat beside her. "We're going to be just fine."

Sixteen on Four Wheels & Finding Dates

Part 1: Part 1: Navigating Northwood High on Four Wheels, Two First Dates, & Why We Ride on Saturday

Date: 2001-10-15 at 07:10 America/New_York

Monday, October 15, 2001, 7:10 AM — Rolling the “Blue Mile” & The Brass Elevator Key

“Keep your speed dial on two until we clear the Commons tiles, Nate, or the vibration is going to rattle our teeth right out of our heads,” Katie said with a wry smile on Monday morning as the two of us rolled our compact **SwiftChair** power wheelchairs through the pinned-open double fire doors of **Northwood High School**.

Beneath our ten-inch solid drive wheels, the textured quarry tiles of the Northwood High Commons buzzed like a washboard before giving way to the smooth, polished linoleum of the main academic corridor everyone called the **“Blue Mile.”**

It was the start of our second full week navigating eleventh grade on four wheels instead of two feet, and physically, the difference was like night and day.

Back in September, walking from the morning bus loop to first period had left our calves cramping, our knees trembling, and our shoulders aching from the weight of our backpacks before the first bell even rang. Now, thanks to the Section 504 Medical Mobility Plan that Dr. Chen had signed and Dad had walked into the principal’s office, neither Katie nor I carried a single textbook between classes. A duplicate set of our Junior-year textbooks sat on a designated shelf in each of our classrooms, and clipped to our lanyard ID badges alongside our house keys were two shiny brass **Vanguard Elevator** keys issued by the school custodian.

Socially, however, showing up to your Junior year of high school in matching power wheelchairs was like dropping a boulder into the middle of a swimming pool.

As Katie and I glided side by side down the right-hand lane of the Blue Mile with our right index fingers resting lightly on our armrest joysticks, the noisy wall of lockers ahead of us reacted the exact same way it had all last week. Conversations dropped to sudden, awkward whispers as we rolled past. Kids who had known us since sixth grade either stared straight down at their sneakers as if looking at a power wheelchair might be rude, or leaped three feet out of our path against the lockers as though we were driving runaway forklifts.

When we reached the B-Wing stairwell at the end of the hall—where two hundred students were jostling up the concrete steps toward the second floor—I pulled my brass key on its retractable lanyard reel, inserted it into the keyhole beside the heavy gray door of the school’s service elevator, and turned it clockwise.

With a slow mechanical clunk, the sliding metal door rattled open, releasing the familiar scent of lemon floor wax and damp mop buckets. Katie and I rolled our compact power chairs straight inside side by side, and as the door slid shut, sealing out the roar of the stairwell, Katie reached her left hand across the two inches between our armrests and laced her fingers through mine.

“Did you see Todd Jenkins jump into the water fountain alcove when we turned the corner by the trophy case?” I asked as the old hydraulic elevator groaned upward toward the second floor at roughly half a mile an hour.

“He nearly knocked his own varsity jacket off his shoulder,” Katie laughed, squeezing my hand as the floor indicator light blinked from 1 to 2. “Remind me again why we used to be afraid of using this elevator?”

“Because we didn’t know how nice it was to get to second period without our legs shaking,” I said honestly as the elevator chimed and the door rattled open onto the upstairs landing. “See you at eleven-forty at our table?”

“Count on it,” Katie smiled, giving my hand one last squeeze before we released our fingers and steered in opposite directions down the hall—Katie toward first-period U.S. History, and me toward first-period English.

Monday, October 15, 2001, 11:45 AM — Head Over Heels for Heather & Katie’s Guarded Heart

“You were smiling all the way from the milk cooler to the table, Nate,” Katie teased gently four hours later as the two of us parked our compact power wheelchairs side by side at the open end of our sunlit corner cafeteria table and clicked our joystick motors off. “Let me guess: **Heather Collins** sat next to you in second-period Computer Lab again?”

I felt my ears turn warm all the way to the tips as I set my brown paper lunch bag beside our spiral *Quantum Basic* notebook.

“She moved her chair right next to my power chair for the whole ninety-minute block,” I admitted, unable to keep the grin off my face as I poked Katie’s straw into her apple juice box for her and handed it across our armrests. “When everybody else in the row stepped around my wheelchair like it was radioactive, Heather didn’t even blink. She showed me wallet photos of her family, helped me pick a color palette for our *Quantum Basic* menu screen, and asked if I wanted to sit with her at the computer table every day this semester.”

The truth was, I wasn’t just crushing on Heather Collins—at sixteen years old, I was completely, head-over-heels in love with her. From the first week of Junior year in Room 204, Heather had treated me with a warm, effortless kindness that made my heart race every time she walked through the classroom door.

Beside me, Katie took a sip of her juice box, her expression softening with genuine happiness for me before a quieter, more thoughtful look crossed her face.

“What about **Ryan Miller** in third-period Chemistry?” I asked, reaching my right hand across the gap between our chairs to take Katie’s left hand on the laminate tabletop. “You said on Friday that he kept leaning across the lab bench to talk to you.”

“He did again today,” Katie said, though her voice was noticeably more reserved than mine. Ever since seventh grade—when Brandon had dumped her in the middle of the hallway and left her sobbing beneath the blue butterfly in her bedroom—Katie had kept a careful, protective wall around her heart when it came to boys. “Actually,

while we were cleaning up our beakers at the accessible lab sink, Ryan asked if I wanted to go out with him to **Emerald Creek Mall** this weekend. And he asked if you had a girlfriend you wanted to bring along so we could make it a double date."

My breath caught in my throat.Neither Katie nor I had ever been on a real high-school date before.

"Wait—what did you tell him?" I asked.

"I told him I'd talk to you at lunch first," Katie said carefully, her fingers tightening around mine. "Honestly, Nate, I don't know about Ryan. He's nice enough when we're lab partners, but I can't tell if he actually likes *me* or if he just likes having someone who balances his chemical equations for him. Still… I see the way your whole face lights up whenever you talk about Heather. And if we go together as a double date on Saturday afternoon, neither one of us has to go through our first high-school date alone."

"Why Saturday specifically?" I asked, glancing at the calendar inside my binder.

"Because I checked Dad's printed **CVTA Route 15** schedule on the refrigerator this morning," Katie explained, tapping the timetable notes she had copied into the margin of our notebook. "Remember the alternating branch rule at Old Emerald Creek Road and Military Highway? **Route 15** only serves **Emerald Creek Mall** Monday through Saturday. On Sundays, every single trip runs straight down to **Robert Hall Boulevard** and skips **Emerald Creek Mall** completely. So if we want to take the bus to the mall ourselves, it has to be on Saturday."

"Then let's do Saturday," I said earnestly, squeezing her hand so she knew my promise from seventh grade hadn't changed one bit. "I'll ask Heather in Computer Lab on Wednesday morning, and you tell Ryan we'll meet them at the **Emerald Creek Mall** upstairs food court at twelve-forty-five on Saturday. And Katie—if Ryan acts weird for even one second, you and I have our bus fare in our pockets and each other right beside us."

Wednesday, October 17, 2001, 10:05 AM — Two Very Different Reactions

"A Saturday afternoon double date at **Emerald Creek Mall** with you and Katie?" Heather Collins repeated on Wednesday morning in second-period Computer Lab, her warm hazel eyes lighting up with an immediate, genuine smile that made my chest feel weightless. "I would love to, Nate! How are you and Katie getting over to Emerald Creek?"

"We live right near Military Highway and Indian River Road now, so we're taking **CVTA Route 15** at twelve-twenty-five," I explained honestly, bracing myself just in case a high-school girl thought riding the city bus on a first date was uncool. "The high-floor bus has a hydraulic wheelchair lift in the front stairwell, so Katie and I can roll our power chairs right aboard together without Dad having to break them down for the trunk of his car."

Heather didn't flinch or look embarrassed for a fraction of a second. Instead, her smile grew even warmer.

“That is so smart—my dad can drop me off at the main mall entrance at twelve-forty, and I’ll ride the back glass elevator right up to the second-floor food court to meet you and Katie,” Heather said brightly, reaching over to touch the sleeve of my flannel shirt. “I can’t wait for Saturday, Nate.”

Two hours later at Fourth-Block lunch, however, when Katie rolled up to the corner table and parked beside me, I could see immediately from the tight set of her jaw that her conversation with Ryan Miller in third-period Chemistry had gone very differently.

“Ryan agreed to meet us at twelve-forty-five on Saturday,” Katie said quietly, unwrapping her sandwich and taking my right hand across the table, “but we didn’t even make it out of the Chemistry lab before he got weird about two things.”

“What did he say?” I asked, frowning.

“First, when I told him we were meeting at **Emerald Creek Mall**, Ryan puffed his chest out and said, *‘Oh, I’ll drive over to your house in my coupe and pick you up—just fold your wheelchair up and throw it in my trunk,”*” Katie recounted, shaking her head in disbelief. “I tried to explain to him twice that a motorized power wheelchair with a battery box and solid drive wheels doesn’t just fold flat like an umbrella stroller, and that even if Dad disassembled it into four pieces, it wouldn’t fit inside a two-door sports coupe.”

“And what was the second thing?” I asked.

“When I told him that you and I were riding **CVTA Route 15** to the mall together because we always travel as a pair,” Katie said, her blue eyes steady and guarded as she looked at me, “Ryan frowned and said, *‘Wait—you’re bringing your brother on the bus instead of riding with me? Don’t you ever go anywhere without Nate?’* I looked him straight in the eye and told him, *‘No, Ryan. Nate is my twin brother, and he comes first.’* He backed down and said he’d meet us at the food court at twelve-forty-five, but… I have a feeling Saturday is going to be a very short test for Ryan Miller.”

Part 2: Part 2: Cousin Wesley, Ryan’s Escalator Exit, & Two Dates at Emerald Creek Mall

Date: 2001-10-20 at 12:45 America/New_York

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 12:45 PM — The Second-Floor Food Court & Cousin Wesley

“Nate! Katie! You guys made it right on time!” **Heather Collins** called out with a radiant smile at twelve-forty-five on Saturday afternoon, waiting for us right outside the sliding doors of the rear glass elevator on the second floor of **Emerald Creek Mall** so we wouldn’t have to navigate the crowded food court alone.

Twenty minutes earlier, Dad had walked with us out to the corner of **Military Highway and Indian River Road**, pressed a twenty-dollar bill into each of our hands, and waved from the sidewalk as Katie and I rode the **Elevate-U** hydraulic

stairwell wheelchair lift aboard the `12:25 PM` Saturday southbound **CVTA Route 15** (`Bus #914`). Right on schedule at `12:45 PM`, the high-floor **Beacon V** bus had dropped us off at the mall entrance.

Before I could even click my joystick speed dial down to one, Heather stepped straight up to my compact **SwiftChair** power wheelchair, leaned down without a trace of hesitation, and wrapped her arms around my shoulders in a warm hello hug that sent my heart soaring into the skylights.

“Hi, Nate,” Heather said softly against my cheek before straightening up and smiling just as warmly at my twin sister. “And hi, Katie! I rode the glass elevator up from the first floor two minutes ago so we could all roll into the food court together.”

“Thanks for waiting for us by the elevator, Heather,” Katie said, her guarded posture relaxing noticeably at how naturally Heather included both of us.

As the three of us headed into the cavernous second-floor food court—where the high tented ceiling echoed with weekend chatter and Bobby Vanguard’s 1982 synth-pop classic *“Moving Up the Escalator”* drifted down from the PA speakers above the twin chrome banks of center escalators—**Ryan Miller** strolled over from the balcony railing in his letterman tee.

Unlike Heather, Ryan didn’t look thrilled to see our two compact power wheelchairs rolling side by side.

“Hey,” Ryan said, glancing down at Katie’s motorized drive wheels as we pulled two plastic chairs away from one side of a four-top table so Katie and I could park our power chairs side by side facing Ryan and Heather. “Katie, I still don’t get why you made me meet you here instead of letting me pick you up in my car. You seriously couldn’t just fold that chair up and stick it in my trunk?”

“Ryan, I told you on Wednesday—it’s a power wheelchair,” Katie replied evenly, tapping the black battery box beneath her seat. “It has electric motors and heavy batteries. It doesn’t fold up like a beach chair, and Nate and I ride **Route 15** together.”

Ryan let out a loud, skeptical sigh, slumping into his seat across from Katie as Heather and I brought back our lunch trays from **Crown Burger** and **Annie’s Pretzels**.

Halfway from the counter to the table, the progressive neuropathy weakness in my left forearm flared under the weight of the plastic food tray. My left wrist trembled, tipping my large cola cup toward the edge of the tray. Instantly—without me having to say a single word—Katie glided her power chair half a foot to her right, slid her left hand under the corner of my tray to steady it onto the table, pinched open the paper wrapper on my straw, and laced her left fingers through my right hand between our armrests while my wrist tremor settled.

Across the table, Ryan stared at our joined hands as if we had just committed a felony.

“Are you kidding me right now, Katie?” Ryan snapped, setting his burger down on its wrapper and leaning forward across the table. “First you refuse to ride in my car unless your brother comes along, and now you’re sitting here holding his hand and opening his straw while you’re supposed to be on a date with *me*? Who’s number one here—me or your brother?”

The noisy food court seemed to fade into background static around our table. Beside me, Katie didn’t flinch, and she didn’t let go of my hand.

“Nate is number one in my life, Ryan,” Katie said clearly, looking him straight in the eyes. “He is my twin brother. We’ve been through everything together, and he is always going to come first.”

Ryan scoffed, his face flushing red as he turned toward Heather next to him, clearly expecting her to back him up. “Heather, are you seeing this? Doesn’t it bother you that your date is sitting here holding his sister’s hand and acting like they’re glued together?”

Heather looked at Ryan with calm, unmistakable steel in her hazel eyes—and then reached across the tabletop to lay her right hand warmly over my left hand.

“No, Ryan, it doesn’t bother me one bit,” Heather said firmly. “In fact, I love how close Nate and Katie are.”

Ryan blinked at her. “What? Why?”

“Because my fourteen-year-old cousin **Wesley**—my mom’s sister’s son—is severely developmentally disabled,” Heather explained, her voice steady and proud as she looked from Ryan to Katie and me. “Wesley and I grew up together, and whenever the two of us go anywhere, I hold Wesley’s hand, I hug him, and we look out for each other the exact same way Nate and Katie do. If I ever screamed at Nate or got jealous of him for holding his twin sister’s hand and hugging her, I would be disrespecting the exact relationship I have with Wesley.”

Heather turned her gaze back to me, her eyes shining with so much warmth and affection that my throat went tight.

“I knew before I ever said yes on Wednesday that Nate and Katie travel as a pair,” Heather continued softly. “And watching the way they take care of each other only makes me love Nate more.”

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 1:20 PM — Ryan’s Escalator Exit & “Did You Bring Two Dates?”

Ryan stared from Heather to Katie and me, his ego visibly bruised beyond repair as he realized neither girl at the table was going to bend to him.

“Whatever,” Ryan muttered bitterly, shoving his plastic food-court chair back across the quarry tile and standing up. “If I wanted to play second fiddle to your twin brother and a pair of wheelchairs all afternoon, I would’ve stayed home. Have fun riding the city bus, Katie.”

Heather, Katie, and I watched in silence as Ryan snatched his jacket off the back of his chair.

Beside me, Katie kept her chin up, but I felt the slight tremor in her left hand where her fingers were still laced with mine, and I saw the hurt glistening at the corners of her blue eyes. Even though Katie had stayed guarded with Ryan all week—and even though part of her had figured from the start that this wouldn't work—having a boy walk out on her in the middle of a crowded food court still stung.

And then Ryan did something that turned my blood to ice.

To leave the second-floor food court, the rear hallway leading to the glass elevator and the west stairwell was right behind our table. Instead, Ryan walked thirty feet straight out to the center atrium railing, turned around to look directly at Katie sitting in her compact power wheelchair, and stepped deliberately onto the moving metal steps of the central **down escalator**—taking the escalator down to the first floor in a massive, calculated show of disrespect because he knew Katie's disability made it physically impossible for her to follow him down those stairs.

As the top of Ryan's head sank below the second-floor floorplate on the escalator, a long, quiet breath left Katie's lips.

"I kind of figured before we even got off the bus today that it wouldn't work with him," Katie admitted quietly, blinking back the moisture in her eyes as she looked down at her lap belt. "Still… taking the escalator just to rub it in that I can't follow him was pretty low."

"It wasn't just low, Katie—it was disgusting, and he didn't deserve five minutes of your time," Heather said immediately, stepping around the corner of the table to rest a gentle, supportive hand on Katie's shoulder while I squeezed Katie's left hand with everything I had. "And we are *not* letting him ruin our Saturday. Come on—finish your pretzels, and let's the three of us go walk the second floor of the mall together!"

Katie looked up at Heather in surprise, then glanced at me.

"You're sure you don't mind me tagging along on your date, Heather?" Katie asked softly.

"Are you kidding? You're not tagging along—we're a team today," Heather smiled warmly.

Ten minutes later, after we cleared our trays, the three of us rolled out of the food court and into the wide, sunlit second-floor concourse of **Emerald Creek Mall**. I rolled down the center of the polished terrazzo walkway in my compact power chair, with Katie rolling right beside my left armrest holding my left hand, and Heather walking right beside my right armrest holding my right hand.

Halfway past the **Oak & Iron Outfitters** and **The Literary Alcove** upper-level windows, three guys from our Junior-year History and English classes at **Northwood High School**—Marcus, Devon, and Chris—came walking out of the music store carrying CD bags.

None of the three had ever had a class with Katie and me at the same time, so they had no idea Katie was my twin sister—and as their eyes landed on me rolling down the mall in my power wheelchair flanked by two pretty sixteen-year-old girls holding both of my hands, all three of them stopped dead in their tracks.

Marcus grinned from ear to ear and gave me an impressed salute.

“Whoa, Prairie—save some for the rest of us, man!” Marcus laughed, nudging Devon’s elbow as they walked past. “Did you seriously bring *two* dates to **Emerald Creek Mall** today?!”

For one second, Heather, Katie, and I blinked at each other—and then all three of us burst out laughing so hard that every bit of the sadness Ryan had left behind vanished into the vaulted ceiling of the mall.

“Tell them yes, Nate!” Heather giggled, squeezing my right hand as Katie laughed beside us. “Let the whole eleventh grade think you’re the smoothest guy at Northwood High!”

“With the two prettiest girls in Virginia Beach on either side of my chair,” I grinned, looking from Katie’s bright, restored smile on my left to Heather’s glowing face on my right, “I’m definitely not correcting them.”

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 2:40 PM — A Hug for Me, A Handshake for Katie, & Route 15 Home

We spent the next hour browsing the second-floor music and book aisles at **The Literary Alcove** together before riding the rear glass elevator down to the first-floor concourse at two-forty so Katie and I could catch the `2:48 PM` northbound **CVTA Route 15** bus back up Military Highway.

Just outside the automatic sliding glass doors in the crisp October sunshine, Heather’s father pulled up to the pickup curb in his burgundy sedan and gave a friendly wave through the windshield. Fifty feet down the wide concrete sidewalk, the blue-and-yellow **CVTA** bus stop sign stood waiting for the `2:48 PM` bus.

Stopping beside us on the sidewalk, Heather turned to me first. Bending down in front of my power chair, she wrapped both arms warmly around my neck and hugged me close, her cheek pressing against mine for a long, unhurried moment.

“Today was the best first date I’ve ever had, Nate,” Heather whispered in my ear before pulling back with a bright smile. “Same computer table on Monday morning?”

“Same computer table on Monday morning,” I promised, my face glowing.

Then Heather turned to Katie’s power wheelchair right beside mine. Instead of giving a polite wave from a distance, Heather stepped squarely in front of my twin sister, met Katie’s blue eyes with genuine warmth and respect, and extended her right hand.

“It was really great hanging out with you today, Katie,” Heather said earnestly. “Next Saturday, maybe the three of us can bring my cousin Wesley along and get pretzels together.”

Katie looked at Heather’s outstretched hand, and a real, unguarded smile broke across my sister’s face as she reached out with her right hand and shook Heather’s hand warmly.

“I’d really like that, Heather,” Katie said. “See you at school on Monday.”

We watched from the sidewalk as Heather climbed into the front passenger seat of her father’s car and waved out the window until the sedan merged onto the ring road. As soon as her dad’s car turned the corner, Katie and I steered our compact power wheelchairs side by side down the sidewalk to the **CVTA Route 15** bus stop and laced our inner hands together while we waited for the `2:48 PM` high-floor **Beacon V** bus to round the loop.

“Well,” I said quietly, looking over at my twin sister as the familiar white bus with its horizontal blue-and-green **TRT** stripes and **`CVTA`** door sticker signaled toward our curb, “one out of two first dates wasn’t bad.”

“Are you kidding, Nate?” Katie smiled, squeezing my hand as the bus pulled up and the operator switched on the **Elevate-U** hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift. “Finding out in twenty minutes that Ryan was a jerk—and finding out that Heather loves you *and* gets us completely because of her cousin Wesley? I’d call that a hundred percent success.”